

Free Indeed!

St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 16, 6/16/2021 (ns), the Wednesday before Pentecost

Pentecost and the Sunday of All Saints.

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Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to all those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter at least twice each month. This is the 16th sent to 81 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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Questions about Pentecost

Don't cheat! Try to answer the questions. Some of the articles in the newsletter may help you. The answers are at the end. No peeking!

Question 0: The Symbol of Faith. What does the Symbol of Faith say about the Holy Spirit? You should know the whole creed by memory. Which council wrote the following lines? “And in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the Giver of Life, who proceedeth from the Father, who with the Father and the Son together is worshipped and glorified, who spake by the prophets.”

QUESTION 1. Ministry of the Holy Spirit. What is the ministry of the Holy Spirit?

QUESTION 2. Symbols for the Holy Spirit. What are two symbols for the Holy Spirit? Explain why symbols are used to depict Him, and the reason for these particular symbols. How did the Holy Spirit manifest Himself on the day of Pentecost? Describe three ways. Name other symbols for the Holy Spirit.

QUESTION 3 – Most Famous Prayer to the Holy Spirit. What is the complete text of the most famous prayer to the Holy Spirit? Which services is it used in? There are certain days when it is not used. When?

QUESTION 4 – Procession of the Holy Spirit. Describe the procession of the Holy Spirit, and the relationship of the Holy Spirit to the other persons of the Godhead. Is it important to be exact? Describe a popular heresy concerning the procession of the Holy Spirit, and the two divinely inspired documents that directly refute this heresy. What are the implications for those who believe this heresy?

QUESTION 5 – Gift of Tongues. Describe the gift of tongues, and comment upon the claims of many who say they have this gift today.

QUESTION 6 – Day of Pentecost. Describe the day of Pentecost, from memory. If you do not remember much, maybe you need to read the scriptures more often? We have a lot of time to be dead, but not much to learn the things that pertain to our salvation.

QUESTION 7. Prophet David's important teaching re: Holy Spirit. What very important prayer did the Holy Prophet David make concerning the Holy Spirit, and what are its implications? Hint - All Orthodox Christians should be saying this prayer every day.

QUESTION 8 – Giving and losing of the Holy Spirit. How is the Holy Spirit given? Can He be lost? How?

QUESTION 9 – The Jewish and Christian Feast of Pentecost. Why is the feast of Pentecost called 'Pentecost'? What Jewish feast was occurring at the same time? Explain some of the implications of the juxtaposition of the Jewish feast and the Giving of the Holy Spirit to the church.

QUESTION 10 – Services for Pentecost. Describe the services for Pentecost, and do not neglect to mention any special prayers that are said. This day is also unique in that the main scriptural text for the feast is not from the Gospels. Why?

http://www.orthodox.net/questions/pentecost_1.doc

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Prison Ministry News

A young man will move to live in Marshall permanently, by at least August 1. We anticipate the first parolee coming into Marshall in that

month. Father David and I wish we could do much more but at least we are beginning to help you find housing and even a way to make a living.

Pastoral Letter on Pentecost.

June 3/16, 2019

On the Eve of the radiant day of Pentecost, I thought I might try to write small letter to you. It is for my flock, in the church, in the prison, and anyone who might listen on social media. I am not trying to write anything eloquent, but only something from my heart to your heart. **Without Pentecost, there is no fulfillment of Pascha.** We must understand the moral implications of Pentecost. What follows is perhaps a little bit of a meandering eclectic and contemplative catechism about Pentecost

The feast of Pentecost commemorates when the Holy Spirit came down upon the apostles and subsequently to everyone in the entire church. The Holy Spirit manifested Himself as tongues of fire over their heads and enlightened them, and to this day, He enlightens all who desire to have Him within their deep heart.

This feast occurs precisely 50 days after Pascha. In Jewish law, the feast of Pentecost was to commemorate the giving of the law. The Christian Pentecost supersedes that earlier feast and is to help us fulfill the law. Christianity is to fulfill the law of God. In our day, we have people who define themselves as Christians and yet do not attempt to fulfill God's law. This is an abomination. We are made for perfection; one cannot be perfect without striving for perfection. We cannot become perfect on our own, so the Holy Spirit is given to us to guide us in everything.

Why do I say we are made for perfection? We were made in the image of God in order to obtain His likeness. I teach about that almost every day because it is the beginning of everything. God made man so that man could share in the life of the Holy Trinity. It is impossible for someone impure to be in the presence of the fire of God and not be burned up. Therefore, Jesus Christ became man and showed us the way of life, and arranged for this way of life to be taught in the church, and for us to have a path to perfection.

We are not required to be perfected on our own. That is absolutely impossible, and the church understands that the true path of life is to perfection, and it is only possible because of the guidance of the Holy Spirit. How can it not be? If we are made in the image of God, then we share in His attributes, even though we are full of sin. Since God is perfect and simple and holy, we were also made to be these things. The path to becoming these things is by the grace of God and our effort. The Holy Spirit

helps us in all of these things by enlightening us and strengthening us, and helping us to have courage when we are weak, teaching us when we are ignorant, and comforting us when we are downcast.

The Holy Spirit secretly speaks to us, in groanings that cannot be uttered by human language ("Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered." Rom 8:26) We must learn to think spiritually and act spiritually. This is a learned skill. It does not come about passively; it only comes about by our activity, being helped by the mercy of God in everything.

At this time, I want to merely comment about some of the texts from the service of Pentecost. Everyone who cares about their soul should get a hold of these texts and read them multiple times, and read them every year. The Pentecostarion, which contains the feast of Pentecost and Pascha and all the feasts in between, is not that expensive. If you do not have the funds for the Pentecostarion, then these texts can be obtained online. I have them on my computer.

"Come, O ye people, let us worship the Godhead in Three Persons: The Son in the Father, with the Holy Spirit; for the Father before all-time begat the Son Co-ever-existing and Co-enthroned, and the Holy Spirit was in the Father, glorified together with the Son; One Might, One Substance, One Godhead. In worshipping Whom let us all say: O Holy God, Who madest all things by the Son, through the co-operation of the Holy Spirit; Holy Mighty, through Whom we have known the Father, and through Whom the Holy Spirit came into the world; Holy Immortal, the Comforting Spirit, Who proceedest from the Father, and retest in the Son: O Holy Trinity, glory to Thee!" *Doxasticon for the feast, in Tone VIII* —

This hymn is from the Vespers service. It basically explains the prayer that we should be saying every day in our daily prayers, the so-called "Trisagion". That prayer is: "Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal, have mercy on us". You can see from the hymn above that the Trisagion is referring specifically to each of the persons of the Holy Trinity.

We live in a non-dogmatic age. People can call themselves Christians and not even understand the doctrine of the Trinity and not care! We who are Orthodox Christians really do care. We were born to know God, and we

cannot know Him unless we know Him as He truly is. Therefore, all of our services glorify the Holy Trinity, and there are many hymns such as this one that are very explicit. The reason why we must be explicit about our worship is because *God is Who He is*, and we were born to know Him. If we think we know Him and think we know something else about Him that is not true, we are not believing in Him correctly. One cannot make progress in the spiritual life if one does not believe in God correctly. Of course, correct belief is not just knowing facts that are true; it is always living according to those facts that are true.

The following is a portion of the first reading from Vespers. In many great feasts, there are three Old Testament readings called “parables.” This first one should touch our hearts deeply. Our theology is not something that is cold and bare. It is not something just to be memorized, and “stated.” It is something that must bring comfort to us. A characteristic of human life is that we sometimes feel alone. We sometimes feel overwhelmed. If a person struggles for virtue, they will always have moments of feeling overmatched and overwhelmed. If you never have this feeling, then *you are not struggling enough*. One of the names of the Holy Spirit is the “Comforter.” This comfort is a spiritual comfort. It means that we are not alone and that our weakness is made strong by the Spirit. I think the following excerpt embodies that comfort.

“And I will come down and talk with thee there; and I will take of the Spirit which is upon thee, and will put it upon them; and they shall bear the burden of the people with thee, that thou bear it not thyself alone. ...”

“But there remained two of the men in the camp, the name of the one was Eldad, and the name of the other Modad, and the Spirit rested upon them, and they were of them that were written, but went not out unto the Tabernacle, and they prophesied in the camp. And there ran a young man, and told Moses and said: Eldad and Modad do prophesy in the camp. And Joshua the son of Nun, who attended on Moses, one of his young men, answered and said: My lord Moses, forbid them. And Moses said unto him: Enviest thou for my sake? Would to God that all the Lord’s people were prophets, and that the Lord would put His Spirit upon them.” (full reading: Numbers 11:16-17, 24-29)

I included the second part of this reading above, because I’ve encountered many, including myself, who, because of life situations, have felt weak and unable to do what we want to do. Sometimes we, for some reason, believe that we are too insignificant for God. The experience of Eldad and Modad shows that God will help anyone who seeks Him. Of course, we must understand this teaching in an Orthodox way. We cannot be arch-ecumenists and say that truth does not matter, or that how we conduct ourselves in our lives does not matter, or our sexual orientation, or sexual practices, or whatever else, does not matter. We must live according to the law of God as best we can, and no one is insignificant according to God. According to man, most people are insignificant. They are too poor, or too sick, or too weak to order their affairs as they would want, because there are those that are richer than them, and healthier, and more powerful. That is in the world, but in the Holy Trinity, all men are loved the same.

The second reading of Vespers is very famous, and many know of it, but does this knowledge affect your life? The world is full of favoritism, and there is no full and true justice. God is perfectly just. He will give his Spirit to any who seek Him honestly and with a good heart. My experience with many prisoners, and also with people that are in a different kind of prison in the so-called “free world,” is that they feel insignificant and marginalized and don’t fully understand that God does not abide by any of the apparent “rules” of the world. *All God requires of you is that you try!* The ending of this reading reminds me of the words of Christ: “He who endures to the end will be saved” (Cf. Matthew 10:22). We just need a little more endurance, a little more patience. We can do that today, and when tomorrow comes, the Holy Spirit will help us to do it tomorrow also. We are not required to

tomorrow’s work today. That would overwhelm us. We are just required to struggle, to be a little bit more patient, and the Comforter will comfort us.

“And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out My Spirit upon all flesh; and your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams and your young men shall see visions. For upon My servants and upon My handmaids in those days will I pour out My Spirit and they shall prophesy. And I will show wonders in the heavens above and signs upon the earth below, blood and fire and pillars of smoke. The sun shall be turned into darkness, and the moon into blood, before the great and terrible day of the Lord come. And it shall come to pass, that whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved.” [Joel 2:23-32]

The last reading from Vespers should also be very comforting. It is not just comforting, but it is also an “instruction manual”. All of the promises of Scripture are like this. Even when Scripture does not explicitly give us commands, we must understand commands within it.

For instance, this reading tells us that the Holy Spirit will help us to be clean of our filthiness and to be cleansed, and have a new heart and a new Spirit in our heart, which will no longer be stony but will be of flesh (that is, fully alive and active in the virtues). And we are further promised that God will help us to walk in His statutes and keep His judgments and do them. Those are not just promises; they are also commands.

We are to live in a spiritual way. We are to search out to do things that are clean and not filthy, and not have a stony heart, but one that is soft and open to God’s mercy and to giving mercy to others. If we react to someone in some way that is “stony” - and there are so many ways to do this – anger, passive-aggressiveness, judging, gossip, or even just forgetting to pray for someone that is bothering us - we are acting as if we have a stony heart. If we are saying that we must do such and such to survive, and we are not thinking of our brother, we have a stony heart. Do you sometimes feel that you have a stony heart? Do you want to have a new heart? The Holy Spirit will give you this heart, but only with your permission and your activity.

“Thus saith the Lord: I will take you from among the heathen, and gather you out of all countries, and will bring you into your own land; then will I sprinkle clean water upon you, and ye shall be clean; from all your filthiness and from all your idols will I cleanse you. A new heart also will I give you, and a new Spirit will I put within you; and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you a heart of flesh, and I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in My statutes, and ye shall keep My judgments and do them. And ye shall dwell in the land that I gave to your fathers; and ye shall be My people, and I will be your God.” [Ezekiel 36:24-28]

Those who know me well know that I love to speak of various “definitions” of salvation. Do you see the definition of salvation, above? It is a beautiful promise: our stony heart will become a heart of flesh, and our deep and empty heart will be full of the Holy Spirit, and we will no longer sin but be able to walk in all of God’s statutes and His judgments, and He will call us His people. All of that is worth fighting for, very much.

There are many more hymns from the Pentecost service that we could speak of. I will just pick out a few more, and hopefully, you will not find the letter to be tedious.

“By the Holy Spirit, is every soul given life, exalted by purity, and made radiant by the unity of the Trinity in a sacred and mystical manner.” Antiphon I, Fourth Tone

There are antiphons that are sung before the Gospel is read in the Matins service. Usually, there are three sets. On great feasts, we only sing the first antiphon in the fourth tone. The end of that antiphon is as above. We must never forget that God will give us understanding in a mystical way. The purpose of life is to become pure and radiant, and this is only possible by entering into the Trinity. We sing this antiphon so many times

during the year that it gets into our bones and our heart. I hope it comforts your heart.

The following gospel excerpt is from the reading for Pentecost matins, and it also is one of the Resurrection Gospels that is read in some of the Sunday matins services throughout the year. Let's look at the excerpt first, and I will tell you a couple "take-homes".

"The same day at evening, being the first day of the week, when the doors were shut where the disciples were assembled for fear of the Jews, came Jesus and stood in their midst and said unto them, "Peace be unto you." And when He had so said, He showed unto them His hands and His side. Then were the disciples glad when they saw the Lord. Then said Jesus to them again, "Peace be unto you. As My Father hath sent Me, even so send I you." And when He had said this, He breathed on them and said unto them, "Receive ye the Holy Ghost. Whosoever sins ye remit, they are remitted unto them; and whosoever sins ye retain, they are retained.'" (Full reading: John 20:19-31)

On the Day of the resurrection, when the Lord came into the upper room, the first thing He said to his disciples was: "Peace be unto you". This tells us the most important thing we should seek, and if we listen to the church, we will learn exactly how to seek peace. The disciples were not feeling peaceful that day, and even after the Lord spoke with them they were still afraid for many days, until the Holy Spirit came.

Peace is our objective. We want peace, not as the world speaks of peace, but as God speaks of peace. That peace is when the soul is quiet and holy and there is only goodness within it and no sin. This is the peace that you must be seeking. We can find some of this peace even in this world. With will be finding peace in the midst of an un-peaceful world, with its many difficulties just as the disciples were given peace, but it did not manifest immediately.

The Lord also promised the Holy Spirit to his disciples after breathing upon them. They did not receive the Holy Spirit right away; this would happen on Pentecost, fully 50 days later.

Miraculous Stories with St Gabriel (Urgebadze)

Venerable Gabriel (Urgebadze), who passed away less than 30 years ago, is known to Orthodox Christians from all over the world. Today St Gabriel works real miracles, appearing in dreams and helping those who sincerely pray to him, interceding before God even for those who are hopelessly sick. The earthly life of the venerable was also full of miracles. However, the elder tried in every possible way to hide these miracles behind foolishness, asking to keep them a secret until his death. Here are some of these amazing incidents from the life of the saint, told by his spiritual children.

Originally appeared at: [The Catalogue of Good Deeds](#)

Buckets Filled with Cement Flying in the Air Like Magic Carpets

Father Gabriel's sister, Julietta Mikhailovna, once told Mother Paraskeva, the elder's cell attendant, about the miracle that she had witnessed, so that people would know what an amazing person Father Gabriel was.

Once, I came to see Fr Gabriel at the time when he was building a church. He was alone in the house and opened the gate himself. After a short conversation, he said: "Sister, I don't have any time to interrupt my work and I'm hungry. Please bring me a bottle of Georgian yoghurt from the store." I didn't want to take his money, but he insisted, also giving me the keys saying: "I will continue my work. Lock the gate from the outside and when you return, be sure to call me BEFORE you open the gate." I went, but I was a little confused. I did not know any places in that neighborhood to buy yoghurt. I walked a short distance and saw a milkman. I was glad that I managed to fulfill Fr Gabriel's request so quickly and hurried back as

God is not slack regarding His promises, but He does not fulfill them in a way that we always understand. This is why patience is so important. If we are active in the Christian life and struggling, we will learn to be patient.

After the Lord said these things, He also told the apostles that they would have the power to remit sins. That is one of the charisms of the priesthood. We don't have time to talk about that in this letter, but we will talk about it another time.

I will leave you with only two more things. They are very similar, so I will put them together. Let us never forget that Jesus Christ is God and man, so that we could become perfected and become like Him. Let us never forget that the difficulties we encounter in no way will frustrate God and make it impossible for Him to save us. Let us never forget that the Holy Spirit will comfort us and help us in all things and that we must live an active and spiritual way.

"Having attained its purpose, the purest word in a quiet way doth bring the heart to perfection; for having accomplished the work, Christ hath gladdened His friends by distributing the Spirit in the mighty wind and fiery tongues, as He promised." Canon of Pentecost, Ode 1

"That He might heal the minds of sin, the All-ruling God and Word doth prepare for Himself as a spotless dwelling the apostles, in whom the light of the Spirit, One in might and essence with Him, doth now make Its abode." Canon of Pentecost, Ode 5

May God bless you and help you in all things. Let us pray for one another that we become a little bit more patient, that our hearts become a little softer and not stony, and that the Comforter would help us in all things.

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http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/feasts-of-the-lord_2019+pentecost+pastoral-letter.pdf

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soon as I got the jar from the milkman. Out of haste and joy, I forgot Father Gabriel's words about calling him before unlocking the gate and entered the courtyard without warning. I was shocked by what I saw. Buckets filled with cement were travelling through the air emptying themselves right into the frames prepared at the top floor. Father Gabriel was standing in the courtyard below, kneading the cement and pouring it into the buckets. As soon as I entered, he noticed me and realized that I had seen everything. At first, he was angry at me for entering without warning, and then he calmed me down and asked me to keep it a secret. More than thirty years have passed before I told this story to anyone.



When mother Paraskeva mentioned that story to Fr Gabriel, he was offended and said: "Haven't I asked her not to tell this story to anyone? I

have nothing to do with this. I was working alone, and when it became very difficult, God took pity on me! I don't want to talk about it!"

"What do you say, Nodar?"

One of Fr Gabriel's spiritual children named Nodar once told the following story: Father Gabriel once spent several days with my family. We consecrated our house and spent all night talking and praying. Then the elder said, "Nodar, my brother, by six o'clock I have to be in the monastery. Can you take me to Mtskheta?" I agreed, of course. These were the days when absolutely everyone was controlled. We headed to Mtskheta. As we were exiting from Tbilisi, seven armed men blocked our road and demanded to stop the car. Let me remind you that these were the 1990s.

Despite the fact that Elder Gabriel told me not to stop, I was careful and stopped the car. Father Gabriel was sitting very calmly. I got out of the car to show the documents to strangers, but it turned out that they did not want the documents, showing more interest in my car. I resisted, although I understood that a fight with seven heavily armed "knights" was a risky enterprise. At that time, I saw Elder Gabriel get out of the car and walk towards us. Then something extraordinary happened: it was as if a huge glowing pillar descended from the sky, followed by a supernaturally tall, handsome, unearthly man with a staff and a white beard. He struck the ground with his staff, and said in an extraordinary voice: "How dare you stop us?! Shame on you!" It was truly a supernatural phenomenon that shocked everyone. Frightened, the armed people ran in all directions. The one who had all the documents, froze in place and then began to thrust them into my hands asking us to leave as soon as possible.

And then we left. Father Gabriel looked at me and asked: "What do you say, Nodar? I think we did pretty well, didn't we?"

"You Have Saved Me from Death"

Once a woman came to the elder and said:— You have saved me from death, now let me thank you.

She told us the following story: — I live in an old house near the cemetery. Once at night, some bandits broke into it. Out of fear, I began to call Father Gabriel for help. A miracle then happened: the elder appeared instantly, with a club and began to chase after them. The frightened bandits then fled in terror, and the elder disappeared as suddenly as he had appeared.

Visiting the Neighboring Monastery without Getting out of Bed

This story has also been told by mother Paraskeva. "Fr Gabriel was seriously ill when he told me: — I am going to go visit Shavnbada monastery. I thought that he was joking. After some time, I asked him: — Father, have you been to Shavnbada? — Yes, I have. Everything is fine there. They were just having a meal when I arrived.

— Have they noticed you? I asked. "No, why would they? If they had, they would have been surprised. I didn't want to show myself to them. — What was Fr Shio busy with? I asked. "He was counting people," the elder replied.

A few days later, the abbot of the Shavnbada monastery Archimandrite Shio came to see Fr Gabriel. I asked him: — How many are you in the monastery? — I don't know! Some come, some go. I usually count them during meals. Father Gabriel looked at me meaningfully and smiled. I was shocked."

<https://russian-faith.com/saints/miraculous-stories-st-gabriel-urgedadze-n5237>

NB:Gleanings for the Holy Fathers

"NB" is an abbreviation for fancy Latin phrase: "note well". It is certainly important to "note well" holy things. This abbreviation is used in a lot of social media.

Quotes from a letter about "PRISON MINISTRY AWARENESS SUNDAY"

"To judge sins is the business of one who is sinless, but who is sinless except God? Whoever thinks about the multitude of his own sins in his heart never wants to make the sins of others a topic of conversation. To judge a man who has gone astray is a sign of pride, and God resists the proud. On the other hand, one who every hour prepares himself to give answer for his own sins will not quickly lift up his head to examine the mistakes of others." (St Gennadius of Constantinople, The Golden Chain, 53-55)

Do not be angry at anyone and do not hate anyone, neither for their faith, nor for their shameful deeds... Do not foster hatred for the sinner, for we are all guilty... Hate his sins, and pray for him, so that you may be made like unto Christ, who had no dislike for sinners, but prayed for them. (St Isaac the Syrian, Homily 57,90)

If you do not find pity on a sinner who will suffer in flames, then you do not carry the grace of the Holy Spirit, but rather an evil spirit; and while you yet live, you must free yourself from his clutches through repentance." (St Silouan the Athonite)

Do not lose your temper with those who sin. Do not have a passion for noticing every sin in your neighbor and judging it, as we usually do. Everyone will give an answer for himself before God. Especially, do not look with evil intention on the sins of those older than you, with whom you have

no business. But correct your own sins, your own heart. (St. John of Kronstadt, My Life in Christ, 1.6)

If you see your neighbor in sin, don't look only at this, but also think about what he has done or does that is good, and infrequently trying this in general, while not partially judging, you will find that he is better than you. (St. Basil the Great, Conversations, 29) If you see a man who has sinned and you do not pity him, the grace of God will leave you. Whoever curses bad people, and does not pray for them, will never come to know the grace of God. (St Silouan the Athonite, Writings, VII 4, VIII 6)

One who strictly prosecutes the misdemeanors of others will find not condescension towards his own. (St John Chrysostom On the Statutes, 3.6)

Let there always be a preponderance of mercy with you, even though you don't feel such mercy in yourself, as God has for the world ... A cruel and merciless heart is never purified. A merciful man is the doctor of his own soul because as a strong wind from his heart, he drives out the darkness of the passions." (St Isaac the Syrian, Homilies, 41)

Pentecost: Only those who thirst will drink the living water.

In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Today we celebrate the bringing of the Holy Spirit: Pentecost, the fulfillment of the Resurrection in the heart of man. Christ prophesied it Himself, and the fulfillment we hear in the Acts of the Apostles. When we have a feast day, usually the primary reading is that of the Gospel, in terms of in content of the feast, but the event of Pentecost is described in the Acts.

Christ said, "If any man thirst, let him come to me and drink," and He said, "Out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water." The Apostle John tells us this refers to the Holy Spirit, Who was not yet given, but He was prophesying of what would happen when it was given. "If any man thirst, let him come to me and drink." The Holy Spirit is available to us, if we thirst. Abundant water, cool water, fresh water. Not water from a cistern, but water from a living spring is available to us -- but only if we thirst. If we don't thirst, then the water that we partake of is flat and lifeless and tepid. We must thirst.

This is the key to the Christian life -- thirst: thirst for righteousness, thirst for Christ. Then, out of your belly indeed shall flow rivers of living water. Think of the image, of what this means. Continual activity, continual purity -- because water purifies, especially flowing water. It scours the ground, and cleans, takes waste away, continually flowing and purifying and cleansing. This is what happens in the heart of man -- but only if we thirst. We must thirst for that good water, the water that Christ also spoke of with the woman at the well, St. Photini. If you thirst, then indeed, you will have living water.

If you don't thirst, if you don't put the priorities in your life wholly towards learning of the sweetness of God, then you won't experience this living water. You might experience a little of it, sort of like being at the spray of a waterfall. You don't experience the power of the water, but you feel some of the mist. This is not for us Christians. We want to feel the full force of the water. But we must thirst.

"As many as have been baptized into Christ have put on Christ." This "putting on" is our action, our desire, our continual living in Christ. May it be that we would truly live as Christians. The Spirit makes it possible. It's all there for us. Abundant grace is present, and abundant grace is continually shed upon us. And we would have all of this grace if we thirsted. To the extent that we thirst for things that are not godly and that distract us, to that extent, we don't have this living water.

And the sad thing is, it's not something we can know, obviously. Many times, when you do something wrong in life, it's evident that you did something wrong. You can tell if you make a mistake in building something, if you cut a board too short, or do something an incorrect way, or something of that nature, your error becomes apparent to you. Or even in human relationships, oftentimes, we can tell if we've made a mistake, and sometimes we have the opportunity to correct it. But, if we don't know that we have this living water, we won't know. It's not something that we can know of to correct because this is a type of knowledge that is wholly beyond us. It's utterly outside of our carnal frame of reference. So, if we miss this living water, if we don't have water springing out of our belly, any

man *won't know it*. To me, that is the greatest tragedy of life -- to not know the grace of God when it is presented to us.

All of us, if we don't struggle, if we don't thirst, we won't experience grace. I've concluded that the reason that some things in our faith are not explained thoroughly is that those who need the explanation would not understand it because they haven't experienced it. Only those that genuinely thirst can truly understand the wisdom and the mercy and the might and the beauty of God, and the excellence of His plan for us. All of us may have realized a small portion of that plan, have small bit of knowledge of God. And may it be that with every single one of us, God is abiding in us, and cleansing us. But may it be for all of us especially that out of our bellies would flow living water. Not just a trickle, not just a drop at a time, not a stagnant pool, but continual activity in Christ, continual knowledge, mounting up like eagles.

It's all there for us. Jesus Christ provided the way; He made our flesh capable. And then, not only did He make our flesh capable, but He sent the Spirit. Why? So that we would know what we can do, that we would know of the mercy and the beauty of God. Truly any man who knows God does not sin. We have to be honest with ourselves and say, to that extent, we don't know God because God makes Himself known to the pure. Or actually -- thank God for this -- He makes Himself known to those who want to become pure. To those who struggle to become pure, He reveals Himself, by degrees. And then we become more aware of Him, and more aware of what's wrong with us. And we leave one; we cleave to the other. But if we do not struggle, life goes on, the waves of life, and we don't even know what we've missed.

That is not the way it should be, brothers and sisters. Follow the words of our Lord. "If any man thirst." You must be a man, woman, child, who thirsts, who desires. And then, in line with this thirst and this desire, do what is necessary to accomplish your task. Ask, pray, struggle to be correct in the way you think, to not judge, to not hate, to not lust, not be lazy, and all the rest. We know in our hearts; we know in our minds, especially in our minds, the things we should do or not do, in a kind of general overview of the Christian life. That is only barely the surface, barely the crust of the bread. Inside the loaf is the knowledge of God, and purity, and sanctity, and completeness, absolute perfection. It is for us. It is for all men, but it is only for those who thirst. Those who do not thirst do not drink much of the water, and they do not have water springing up in themselves.

Let this not be so for us. Let's thirst. Let's desire all the grace God wishes to give us. Let's turn our back on that which is ugly, and ordinary, and temporal, and unclean, and useless, and let's turn towards our Lord, and remember what he has done. Let us try to make our soul a place where the Holy Spirit wishes to live. Let us sweep it and garnish it, and protect it, so that the Holy Spirit would desire to stay and warm us. And let us have this water springing up within us, changing us, making us "more than conquerors." May God help us to desire Him. Amen.

Acts 2:1-11 John 7:37-52: 8:12. 2001

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-00_2001.html

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-00_2001.doc

Pentecost. "Out of His belly shall flow rivers of living water. "Why the belly?"

In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, Amen.

"He that believeth on me, as the Scripture hath said, out of His belly shall flow rivers of living water." So our Lord said on a feast of Pentecost -- before the feast of Pentecost that we celebrate, during His earthly ministry when He promised the Spirit; because the living water is the Spirit, and concerning it we hear this wonderful image: "Out of his belly shall flow forth rivers of living water."

Now what is the belly for, what does the belly signify? In Philippians, it says: "their god is their belly."¹ The belly can be about corruption,

selfishness, death, indulgence; the belly is about the earth. The belly commands that we eat every day. Sometimes the belly commands that we eat too much. It makes us tired, unwilling to pray, unwilling to work. The belly is one of the least honored members of the body. Indeed, couldn't there be a better place for the waters to flow? What about from the head, from the eyes, from the hands? The Lord said, from his belly shall flow forth rivers of living water. Why is this?

The Lord Jesus Christ came to make it possible for us to be incorrupt. The belly, certainly, is the sign of corruption, the sign of our being rooted to the earth. He can clean up everything.

When he sent His Holy Spirit upon mankind, it was so that the things of Christ would be revealed to those who would be willing to listen, and they would become completely alive. Everything would be cleaned, just as water that is rushing cleans and freshens everything. So that even those parts of us which are dirty, which resist becoming perfected, the Lord will indeed perfect.

Water cannot be held back when it is in a torrent; everything in its path is pushed out of the way. So it is with the Holy Spirit. But there is a difference: when a flood comes upon us, it's not of our own will that the water comes, and the water destroys things that are precious to us. But the flood of the Holy Spirit comes only if we desire it. If, of our will, we desire to follow the things of God, then indeed the torrent will come. The torrent will flow and never end. Anything that is ungodly that is in our way of the keeping of the commandments will be scoured away, will be pushed away, and the water will flow eternally-- out of our belly, out of every part of us.

Now, the Pharisees' captains-- the soldiers attending to their dirty work-- certainly spoke correctly: never had any man spoken as this man²; never has any man done as this man. He lived the life of perfection in the body, and made us capable, and He promised that He would make us capable. And the Holy Spirit enables us to realize the power of the Resurrection, to become eternally fresh and new, to become perfect, even out of our belly.

The Holy Spirit is also fire. Not just water, but also fire; these are two things that in nature do not exist together—one destroys the other. But according to God, these things can coexist.

Fire burns away that which is trash, that which is unclean. Fire purifies. Fire softens. Fire warms. And we need the fire of the Holy Spirit to burn away impurity in our soul, and we need the warmth of the Holy Spirit to encourage us. He is called Comforter—He comforts with fire; He comforts by warming our hearts, by giving us that sure and certain hope³ that indeed we can be changed.

And He is water, eternally giving us life, refreshment, invigorating us; a spring that never, ever ends. A drought will never come upon he who has the Spirit; fire and water in the soul of a Christian, each doing their part, each from the same Spirit.

The Holy Spirit abides in a Christian. Until the promise was given, the Holy Spirit did not live in men; all the things that were accomplished were accomplished by the Spirit outside. Even the prophets who spoke by the Spirit: the Spirit did not live in them. He inspired them, and they were still unable to accomplish perfection. But now the Comforter is given to us, and

we can become perfected. Anything impure, anything temporal can all be changed-- can become perfected, clean, can become light, life. Today when we celebrate the fulfillment of the Resurrection in man, the Lord has given us everything we now need.

He lived on the earth and showed us the perfect way of life; the way of life that leads to eternal life, to true happiness; no other kind of happiness is possible. Only by following the will of God can we truly be happy. He showed us this. He showed us the way to live, of having priorities, to follow the commandments. But showing this would not do us any good unless He also made us capable of doing what He shows us, because we weren't capable of following His examples; we're strangers and aliens, as the apostle said⁴, far from God, unable to completely follow the commandments, not so that we could have rivers of living water in our belly springing out; not so that we could be wholly perfected and have nothing ever that is corruptible in us. So, He died and resurrected Himself so that our bodies can be resurrected and can defeat corruption.

But even this is not enough. How many people live in the Resurrection? We still see sin, suffering, unbelief, sadness in the world. The Resurrection is for all men, but not all men are able to apprehend it, to clasp it to their bosom.

We need a Comforter, a Guide, and a Helper; that is the Holy Spirit. He is given so that we can live in the Resurrection; so we can apply the lessons the Lord has given us-- and continues to give us on a moment by moment basis-- of how to live, how to think, how to be, how to feel. All these lessons can be applied because the Comforter tells us in groanings that cannot be uttered⁵. Most of what the Holy Spirit does for us we do not see, or feel, or even know, but he does enlighten and change us, and He does make alive. Without the Holy Spirit, the Resurrection would only be a painting on the wall inaccessible to us, beautiful to be sure, but not something that belongs to us. The Holy Spirit makes it belong to us because we can be changed. We don't have to live with corruption.

Out of our belly shall flow forth rivers of living water, because our Lord showed us how to live. He made us capable of living, and gave us a Guide to show us, continually, how to live and to strengthen us.

May the fire and the water of the Holy Spirit continue to enlighten and help all of us, and make us incorrupt forever. Amen.

Note: After this homily was published on our [BLOG](http://frmilovan.wordpress.com/2009/06/08/pentecost-sunday), Fr Milovan Katanic posted a meditation (<http://frmilovan.wordpress.com/2009/06/08/pentecost-sunday>) which was, as he said, inspired by this sermon, and contained many edifying observations. Fr Milovan has an excellent blog, called "[Again & Again](http://frmilovan.wordpress.com)", which I read frequently and recommend - <http://frmilovan.wordpress.com>

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-00_2004.html

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-00_2004.doc

Pentecost If any man thirst... Three important things

In the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Brothers and sisters, there are three very important things that are said in the gospel today. They're right in a row. One is a question. The other is a command or, actually, a suggestion, and the other is the result.

We are celebrating Pentecost today, the coming of the Holy Spirit upon the disciples, the apostles, and all the rest of the believers up to and including us - the Holy Spirit Who enlightens us, Who shows us the way of life, Who speaks to us in groanings that cannot be uttered⁶. He tells us the things of God, the things of Christ; He enlightens us.

But none of this, none of this will happen unless first, we consider this very important question. And we must answer. When you answer a question, a Christian question, it's not something that you say once. It's something that you answer again and again and again. An example is when the Lord said, "Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me?" And he said, "Yea, Lord, I love thee."⁷ And he was asked three times in a row. We are asked that question every day. Do we love the Lord, or do we love the world? So,

we can't answer that question just one time. It has to be answered over and over again.

And here is another question very similar to the question that is posed to us on the Sunday of the Cross: "If any man thirst, if any man will," it says on the Sunday of the Cross, "let him deny himself, take up his cross and follow Me."⁸ Here it says, "If any man thirst, let him come unto Me and drink."

There's a parallel here. How do you come unto Christ and drink? You deny yourself; you take up your cross, and you follow Him. "If any man thirst" - It's a question that needs to be answered every day. Do you thirst?

Thirst, biologically, is just when you feel the need for water, and if you are extremely active, you need to be drinking water even when you don't think you need it. In the Christian life we should be cultivating our thirst, constantly thinking.

How do you cultivate your thirst? I think the easiest way is to compare this life to the next, comparing the person you are with the person you

should be. Compare the promises of God with the way of the world. And if that doesn't make you thirst, then you have a severe problem like unto being that ground that is hard-packed, so that the seed cannot grow.

I'll be honest with you; a priest is preaching to the people that at least have some thirst. If a person has no thirst whatsoever, the Holy Spirit will not fill them; the Holy Spirit will not live in them, no matter how Orthodox they are. Whether their father and mother were Orthodox, it's been in their family, no matter if they serve in the church, no matter if they are clergy. If a person does not thirst for God, then the Holy Spirit will not fill him. So, the first and foremost thing that is necessary for our salvation is for us to thirst, to desire.

Of course, perhaps I am a little ahead of myself. God revealed Himself to us. Otherwise, we would know nothing of Him. So, the first and foremost thing of salvation is God loving us and creating us. But we were created, and we often look to worldly and earthly things instead of spiritual things because they are more immediately tasty to us. They are more immediately pleasurable to us. They are easier to obtain, and the things of God are hidden. So, it takes effort to cultivate a thirst.

So, on this day of Pentecost, I'm asking you: Do you thirst?

Now, the apostles were gathered together on the day of Pentecost and the tongues of flame came and stood over each one of their heads, and they prophesied, and they spoke in other languages. Why did this happen? It was because they were gathered together; they were thirsting. In the fifty days since the Lord had risen, they were together every day in prayer and in fasting, not understanding really about the future. The Lord had spoken to them about this future, but they did not understand, but they stayed in one place so that on the day of the Holy Spirit they were all enlightened. If anyone among their company had left, then on that day they were not enlightened.

So, the first thing that you must do is thirst. And then the next thing⁹ with thirst, find something to slake your thirst. And the only thing that will satisfy us is Jesus Christ. So, we must come unto Him and drink.

Does this make you remember the woman at the well? He said to the woman at the well, "If you ask of me, I'll give you living water."¹⁰ This living water is the Holy Spirit. "He that believeth on me," says the Lord, "out of his belly shall flow forth rivers of living water."¹¹

This metaphor is really wonderful. The belly is also a figure of speech for the heart; it is interesting that the belly is sometimes taken as the heart in Scriptures. The belly is the place where we fulfill our desires; it is a metaphor for all desire. And the Lord will sanctify all of us. If our belly is sanctified, then certainly the rest of us will be as well.

Sometimes people indicate to me that they have trouble believing. It's really difficult. There's a lot of dissonance in the world. We want to be something, and we're not. We try to be good, and yet there are these thoughts that assail us. We try to find Christ, and sometimes He does not seem so near. So, there's this tug of war that's going on all the time. It's a lot easier to believe the things in the world because we see them and we feel them and we experience them rather than the things of God. And anyone who says that they never have any such feelings, I tell you, that person is not telling you the truth.

How do we experience Christ? First, by knowing we need Him. Thirsting. Second, by coming to Him. And the gospel of the Cross is "Deny yourself, take up your Cross and follow Me." So, we are talking work, and not anything that's easy. If you have something you really need and know that the only way to get it is by obtaining something, you must be willing to work for that.

And then what happens? "Out of his belly shall flow forth rivers of living water."¹² I tell you, if out of your belly was flowing forth cool, refreshing, life-giving water, wouldn't you know it? Would any man need to tell you any proofs of Christ? Would you need to have any dogmatic definitions? No. Because God would be within you. You would feel Him

moving. There would be no doubt. This is what we are attempting to obtain, and it is obtainable, and we do believe this because the saints obtained it.

If you are having doubts, then recognize that this is a sign of your own fallenness and weakness, and renew your thirst. Whatever you can do to come to the Lord, do it, and drink of His living water, and you will eventually feel out of your belly this living water. There will be no doubt. There won't be any room for any doubt because the Holy Spirit fulfills all things.

Now, recently I have been saying to you a little statement in some of the writings, some very important things that we have been writing about on the mailing list and on the blog, and that is: *Do what you can do so that eventually you can do what you cannot do.* And this Scripture is basically teaching that same thing.

First of all, you must be thirsty. You must know that you have a need. You have to know that you need God. And I tell you, unfortunately, there are people that don't know this need. Sometimes we don't know this need either. But if we know this need, then let us come to Christ. And you come to Him by being completely pure, never thinking evil thinking thoughts, cursing, having any unclean thoughts, being jealous, lying, being unpleasant, and never being irritable. If you can do this, then that is good, but most people cannot. None of us can do this, not consistently, not every single moment. But we can do some of it; and **"The things we can do, we must do."**

If you can be kind to your neighbors, be kind even if they are not kind to you.

If you can refrain from judging someone or at least refrain from judging with your lips, then do this.

If you can fast, then fast.

If you can come to the services frequently, then do this.

There are many, many other things.

We could speak of hundreds of things that, if you can do them, I tell you, you must do them.

Now, I am convinced as a pastor that there are things, sometimes simple things in the Christian life, that we, for various reasons, are not capable of doing. We say we are lazy, and we don't want to be lazy, but we really don't know how *not* to be lazy. And it seems like every day, we end up being lazy. We don't want to be angry, and yet we get angry. We don't want to have lustful thoughts or hurtful thoughts or remember wrongs, and yet usually, at very usually inconvenient times, these thoughts come to us.

Sometimes things that you and I consider simple, other people consider difficult, like fasting, for instance, or saying our prayers in our morning or continence or any other things. But what you can do, you must do because the Lord says, "Come unto Me and drink, and out of your belly shall flow rivers of living water." And this is the part that you cannot do, but you will be able to do. No man will be saved without great effort.

If you want to show the Lord that you thirst, then evaluate what you can do. Now, can you fast? All right. Can you pray? Can you come to church regularly? Can you commune? Can you confess? Can you tithe? Can you be kind? **Then do these things.**

If these are things that you are capable of doing and you are not doing them, then woe unto you because how can the Spirit come in, because if you are not doing things that you can do, you certainly won't be able to do anything that you're not capable of, and you never will.

So that is what that little aphorism (see above, in bold, and a larger font) that I made up means. It is important, and the Scripture teaches it all the time. I didn't make it up out of the air. It's right in the Scriptures.

So, if you thirst, follow Christ to the extent of your abilities. Perhaps those abilities are not very good right now. But they will become better if you follow according to the extent of your abilities now. And then you will

become better able to do good things later on. And there is no substitute for purity and goodness. Purity and goodness make us know Christ in the way that no one can gainsay, no one can fool us, and no doubts can creep in.

To the pure all things are pure. And since God is pure, if we are pure, we know God without a shadow of a doubt. So, this pure water that is flowing out of the belly is purifying and maintains our purity, but we must struggle for that purity to the extent we have the ability to do so now.

So here is the key to the Christian life. Thirst for God. Thirst for goodness. Thirst for peace. Recognize that you lack something, something very precious that you need. Desire that thing. And then, to the best of your abilities, come to Christ and drink of His water, which He offers. Take up your cross, deny yourself, struggle.

There is no doubt that the Christian life has struggling, but you can either struggle in Christ or struggle outside of Christ. The whole world is

Pentecost. Circumstances, Space and the Spirit. Pentecost is the fulfillment of the Law

In the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. Amen. Brothers and sisters, it is a truism; it is obvious, it goes without saying: Life is full of “circumstances” - difficult times, accusing times, happy times, times when we feel things are all well, times when we think that we don’t know what the next thing is that will happen, and we are full of fear and anxiety. And out of those “circumstances,” those long periods of “space,” punctuated by important events, the Lord speaks to us; the Lord saves us. It’s always been that way. It was like that on Pentecost.

The Spirit was spoken of in the Old Testament quite often, but the Jews did not understand. Jesus Christ spoke of the Spirit quite often, and the Apostles did not understand. And then when He rose from the dead and after He ascended, the Spirit still had not come, and they did not understand. But they were, as the Scripture says, all of one accord, in one place on the day of Pentecost; they were in a state of readiness, so when the Spirit came, they would understand. Do you understand?

Pentecost is a Jewish feast as well as a Christian one. Pascha, or Passover, was celebrated by the Jews to celebrate their escape from Egypt and Pharaoh. After they left and crossed the Red Sea, fifty days later, the law was given to Moses. Pentecost celebrates the giving of the law, the first Pentecost. **The second Pentecost is the fulfillment of the law.**

The Jews (and all mankind) were not able to fulfill the law because they didn’t have the ability. They could know some of the law only in its broad strokes, but they could not follow it very well because they did not have the Holy Spirit, not every man. The Lord showed us later what the law actually meant, especially in the Sermon on the Mount when He spoke of what love, hate, murder, and lust actually are.

In the Old Testament, the Spirit was given only for specific purposes, to prophets and kings, with the anointing of oil. Only a few had the Holy Spirit. In the Christian age, all Christians can have the Holy Spirit.

But I say “can have the Holy Spirit” because we understand that the Holy Spirit does not abide in the person that does not attempt to live a pure life. The Holy Spirit is signified by the dove, which is a very clean animal, so the Holy Spirit will not be where there is filth, only where there is cleanliness or, should I say: where there is the attempt to be clean. The Holy Spirit will abide in the struggler, in the one who desires. The one who doesn’t care, the one who makes excuses -- the Holy Spirit is far from him even though he calls himself a Christian.

Jesus Christ, after He was risen, came to the all the disciples save Thomas, who was missing, and He said -- “Peace be to you,” and then He breathed on them, and said, “Receive ye the Holy Spirit.” Were the apostles immediately peaceful after He did this, or did they immediately receive the Holy Spirit after He did this? **No.** The apostles still had many days of fear that the Romans would crash in at any time and arrest them and crucify them just like their Savior had been. They were unsure of themselves. They

struggling, so you must pick which one you want to do, which struggle you want to have.

“If any man thirst, let him come to Me and drink. He that believeth on Me,” as the Scripture has said, “out of his belly shall flow forth rivers of living water.” And we celebrate the Holy Spirit coming today to make this a possibility for us to have the rivers of living water in our life, but only if we thirst and if this thirst drives us to come after Christ and to follow him. Amen.

Priest Seraphim Holland 2008 http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-00_2008-06-16.html http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-00_2008-06-16.doc

AUDIO: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-00_2008-06-16.mp3

Video: <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=T8Wq1hDXkM> Part 1

<http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9R7wOkUBqAQ> Part 2

waited for fifty days, not knowing when the Spirit would come. It all comes together in the end.

There’s a perfect symmetry about it, but they didn’t know that at the time. **The law given on Pentecost, the Holy Spirit is given so the law could be fulfilled on Pentecost.** In hindsight, it makes perfect sense; they realized it afterwards, but in the midst of it they did not know. So they were waiting an interminable length of time not knowing, but all of one accord and together, and the Holy Spirit came, with the rush of a mighty wind and cloven tongues of fire over their heads, which was nothing that they expected.

And then, because it was found out because of the sound and the commotion, many people came around with all these different languages, and the apostles spoke to all of them, and they were understood. An amazing thing, undoubtedly incredible. And there are incredible things that happen in our lives.

But most of our life is not incredible. Most of our life is just struggle, just trying. Life is “space” punctuated by short events. The Christian who has less “space” in his day, that Christian is the one who is making more progress. Because there should be no “space” in your day, you should live every moment with prayer and with the desire to become what the Lord has ordered you, commanded you to be every moment. So no moment should be wasted. Yet we know, yes, moments are wasted, but if we are waiting on the Lord, He will surely come.

In Pentecost, an incredible event happened, but the most important story is not the event, but what led up to it. We must look closely enough at the “circumstances” under which it happened. These were men who were hunted. These were men who were afraid. Even when He ascended into Heaven, it is said, some doubted. So even in the forty days, even after seeing Him for several occurrences during the forty days, some still doubted. I think we would be among those doubters as well. It’s not so important if you doubt a little bit; it’s not so important if you sin. What’s important is if you desire; if you desire to be filled with God; then you will. Now, with desire comes effort. It’s not just wishing upon a star. It’s effort and change.

So the apostles gave that effort to be together, which was dangerous. It would have been safer to be apart, wouldn’t it? Wouldn’t a large group of people tend to get more attention from the authorities? They stayed together, and the Holy Spirit came, outside of their expectations. Even though the Lord had said to them many times about the Holy Spirit, despite the fact that they, as lovers of scriptures knew references to the Holy Spirit in the Old Testament, they were surprised. It is that way with us too. Not because the Lord doesn’t tell us but because we’re just a little dull and we don’t understand. That’s okay. The Lord will save those who are dull, as long as they wish to become bright. And you become bright by living in the

"circumstances" of your life and seeing God in all things, in every "circumstance," knowing that there is no "space" in your life. Everything is important. And then the Holy Spirit comes to you and comforts you in ways that you cannot understand, and peace comes to you in ways that you cannot understand.

Now, I don't know about you, but I don't always feel peaceful; in fact, I rarely feel peaceful and yet I know that the Lord promised peace. So what do we do with this conundrum? The Lord said, "Peace be to you," and yet we are not in peace. Well, the problem is that we don't live in a peaceful way. The Holy Spirit will teach us this way. But not in some kind of way that is easy.

Pentecost. Their sound hath gone forth into all the world; how do we hear it?

In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

I greet you today on the Holy Day of Pentecost. And on this day, we hear, "As many as have been baptized in to Christ have put on Christ. Alleluia."¹³ And we also hear today, "Their sound hath gone forth into all the world."¹⁴

What is this sound? The sound is of the rushing wind, the mighty wind. But even in the midst of this sound, there are people who are deaf, like the adder that stoppeth up his ears¹⁵, because the Pharisees heard the same sound. The Pharisees saw Christ, saw his miracles, and they didn't believe. They heard -- they heard well -- and they did not believe.

Whether or not there are triflers who cannot believe the bare truth, and sing "Alleluia"¹⁶, the sound is throughout all the world. There is no doubt about that. The apostles have spread, and their apostles, and their apostles, and even now to this time, such a lowly one as myself, being of their line -- not an apostle, but a priest. And the word is still being spread, and you have the option to listen or not to listen.

The Good News is not only that Christ has made our flesh able to live by His Crucifixion and subsequent Resurrection of His own power, making flesh capable of obtaining God. Not only that news, but the good news today is that the Holy Spirit will help us. He is called the Comforter¹⁷. The Holy Spirit searches out the things of God, the deep things of God, things that we cannot even utter, things that we cannot even think, but which motivate us and can change us. He searches out those things, and He gives them to us.

He would give them to everyone, but everyone will not hear. Christ also said in another context, "O Jerusalem, Jerusalem ... how often would I have gathered thy children together, even as a hen gathereth her chickens under her wings, and ye would not!"¹⁸ The Holy Spirit enlightens a man when he wishes to be enlightened. The Holy Spirit fills a man when he empties out of himself that which fills him which is impure and corrupt. But again, I say that the good news is that the Holy Spirit helps us even in emptying ourselves. Without the Holy Spirit, we cannot live. Without the Holy Spirit, we would not actualize the Resurrection in our life; we would not have the ability.

Jesus spoke of the Holy Spirit, and the Holy Spirit speaks incessantly, eternally of Christ. He reveals to us the things of Christ.¹⁹ He doesn't speak of Himself; He speaks of Christ. And Christ occasionally, as well as speaking of His Father and of Himself, will tell us, darkly, about the Holy Spirit. The doctrine of the Holy Spirit, which is pivotal in the Christian faith, is a dark thing. It is not something that is talked about in extreme exactitude. The Holy Spirit enlightens a man like the wind blows²⁰. We don't know how the wind blows. We don't know where it's going to; we don't know where it's coming from. But it brings life to the earth. Somehow, the wind brings

Reality is a whole lot different than our fantasy. *Reality is hard*. We learn to be peaceful by not becoming angry when someone slanders us, by not becoming bitter when someone harms us, by not lusting when we have an illicit desire. This is the path to peacefulness, and it is hard. But God will help because of the Holy Spirit.

The law was given on the first Pentecost by Jesus Christ, and the Holy Spirit was sent to fulfill the law on the second Pentecost. **Let us fulfill the law by living in the "circumstances" of our life. Let there be no "space" in our life but only the Spirit.** May God bless us and help us.

John 20:19-23 Acts 2:1-11

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water to the earth. We don't know how. We might know something of the science, but we don't know precisely how. The same thing is true about the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit blows through the church and enlightens those who will stop and stand in the wind, and desire to change.

Christ said, "He that believeth on me, as the scripture hath said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water..."²¹ We should take a pause sometimes to meditate on the indescribable beauty of the scriptures. "Out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water." What a beautiful image this is -- but not just an image, because out of his belly shall flow the grace of the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit will enliven a man, and just as water flows down the mountain and cannot be stopped, and enriches and enlivens everything, so the Holy Spirit will flow through a man and will never stop, will well up, and up, and never be extinguished, and will enlighten not only this man but all those who are around him, if he lives in the Spirit.

And what is this, "in the Spirit"? We talk about living in the Spirit; what is this? It is nothing less than hearing the will of God, the word of God, the law of God, and doing it. Being obedient to the teachings of the All-Holy Trinity; living according to who God is. That's being in the Spirit. And I tell you, if you live in that way, then you will be enlightened by the Spirit, in things great and small. And you will not be doubting, and God will help you in all things.

But there is an effort involved, an effort involved to allow yourself to be filled with the Spirit. We won't talk today that much about the particulars of the difficulties living the Christian life; that is for other times. Did you notice that in the Acts, it just was the event of the apostles speaking in other tongues to everyone that we speak about. We don't really go into yet how the Spirit enlivens a man, but if you read the book of Acts, you will see. And if you read the Epistles, you will see. And if you read the Gospels, you will see. And if you come to the services and listen to the beauty of our chant, you will see. God will be there. You will feel and know Him. "Out of your belly shall flow rivers of living water." You won't be corrupt anymore; you will be alive. The purpose of our life is to know God. Because to know God is to become like Him because it cannot be otherwise, because he who loves becomes like the one he loves. It always is this way.

Now we have desire. Maybe it's a small desire, perhaps it's a large desire, maybe, in some cases, it is only a desire to have the desire! Regardless, if we have some desire somewhere, God will help us to become like Him. The purpose of our life. There's nothing else that's important. And today, we celebrate that God has given us a great gift so that we can do these things we desire. The Holy Spirit is that great gift. May we be worthy of such a great gift. Amen.

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Sunday of All Saints. Are you ready to confess in the Lord? What is confession in the Lord? Priorities

In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Amen. Today, brothers and sisters, the Sunday after Pentecost, the Sunday of All Saints,

so it is appropriate to read about what it is to be a saint. This Gospel is about the character of the saints. Of course, there are many Gospels that describe holiness. This one is perhaps the best of all.

Now, the question that you should have for yourself is, do you fit in the category of people that the Lord is describing, who are saints?

In order to be a saint, we must be holy – “saint” actually means “holy.” In fact, we are commanded to be holy. If we don’t become holy, we have no part with Christ. Christ came to help us to become holy. He gave us the ability, but we must have the desire and the effort. We are not only called but also commanded to be holy. So to be a saint is to be holy. This is not the calling only of those holy ones we have on our walls, but it is the calling of every person.

We must, as the Lord says, confess Him. He says something that is both great and terrible: “Whosoever shall confess Me before men, him I will confess before My Father which is in Heaven.” And then He says: “Whosoever shall deny Me before men, him also I will deny before My Father which is in Heaven.”

So one must understand what it means to confess. To confess in the Lord is to live as He taught us. It is to have the priorities He taught us to have. So confession involves living the right way, living as Christians. One cannot confess in the Lord and be a thief. One cannot confess in the Lord and cheat people or be an adulterer.

And also confession in the Lord is something that is difficult in our day and becoming more difficult: we must confess with the lips also. We must stand for what is right as Christians. I have been trying to talk about this a little bit more on the blog entries. This is very important. Our age is one in which good is called bad and bad, good. Abominations are called healthy. And to believe that there are abominations is called hateful, close-minded, and backward. It’s happening. I hope you see it.

Now, I have so far, to my knowledge, never in a sermon been political. I don’t want to talk about parties or governments, or particular people. I want to talk about the age we are in. Look at the age we are in: When sinful things are called good, and those who call them sinful are ostracized and even put in prison. Open your eyes. I hope you see it. It is happening. Even the words I am saying now could be taken to be hate speech and inciting to violence.

Now, you all know me; I’m not inciting anyone to violence, except the kind of violence that wins the Kingdom of God, that is, violence against our sins. But eventually, it will happen that this kind of speech will be outlawed. It’s happened in other societies before, and it’s happening before our very eyes.

It is important not only to know theology; it’s also essential to know the reality of what’s going on right in front of you. As a pastor for quite some time now, not at the very beginning because that was 15 years ago, things were not as insane as they are now. The mechanism was not in place to cause people to be subjugated to people’s immoral will. But it’s now in place. A few changes, a few little tweaks, and it will take great courage to be a Christian. Are you ready? Are you ready to say there is sin? Are you ready to say what is good and what is bad? Just see if I’m a prophet or not in five years, ten, three, two. It will come to be that if you want to work at some places or maybe all that you will have to sign a statement of faith which says that you believe things that Christians do not believe. It’s going to happen. Are you ready to confess in the Lord?

It is excellent to talk about beautiful theology, the Resurrection, the Ascension, to talk about God’s love for us. But God’s love for us is realized in us when we live as He lived. And if you look at the way our Lord lived, He was the One who never had a place to lay His head, and eventually, He was crucified. But He was tormented His entire career. This is that side of Christianity that most people who call themselves Christians, don’t want to see. But I, as your pastor, want you to see it.

If you want to be a saint, you must confess. You must stand up for the truth.

I’ll give you one example. There was a time when I was in a company, and they required us to fill out a piece of paper and give something to United Way. I looked at the things United Way did. A lot of them were things that I would not have any part with whatsoever. Some of them were good. Many of them were good. But the money just went into the pot so some could get an abortion, some could go to family planning programs in China. The good was artfully mixed in with the bad. And so we were required to sign a paper. I didn’t do it. Now, in that day and age, I was pressured greatly but was not fired, but I think it would happen that I would be fired now. Are you ready?

Are you ready to confess in the Lord? All right, I’ll tell you how to become ready. The Lord tells us right here. Right after he says, “Whoever shall confess Me, I will confess in him before My Father,” and then the opposite, “if you don’t confess in me, I won’t confess in you before My Father,” He tells us how to live so that we could confess in Him always.

A saint was commemorated just a couple of days ago where a magician recognized the truth about Jesus Christ and immediately confessed and then his head was cut off right there. That’s usually not the way it happens, brothers and sisters. Confession usually is a long process with suffering and testing of your metal, to see whether or not you’re courageous.

I think there are those of us who would be willing to confess and have our heads severed but are we willing to have our houses taken away from us? Have our jobs taken away? Work in menial labor? It’s happened before. It happened in Soviet Russia, in our lifetime. It’s happening now. And it will happen here. So what do you do?

Here is what the Lord tells us. He says: “He that taketh not his cross and followeth not after Me is not worthy.”

Then He says, when Peter asked him a question, “Behold we’ve forsaken all and followed Thee. What shall we have?” And he promises Peter and the other apostles to be able to sit on thrones judging the twelve tribes of Israel but then He said something that’s very comprehensive, and this is the key to whether or not you will be ready to confess when it really is time: “And everyone that have forsaken houses or brethren or sisters or father or mother or wife or children or lands for My Namesake, shall receive a hundredfold. And shall inherit everlasting life.” And He adds something that’s also important: “But many that are first, shall be last and the last shall be first.”

That can mean many things, and one of the meanings is this: **Things are not as they seem.** Don’t believe what the world tells you. Believe what God tells you. And this list of things that were forsaken, not that we should run away from our parents, but these are symbols of things that we want that might get in the way of who God is. And if anything gets in the way of God, we must forsake it. **It’s about priority.**

As a pastor, I’ve seen when people are beset by sins, if they have good priorities, they conquer these sins. I don’t care what it is. If you have good priorities, if you desire to live a Christian life, if you try to pray - I’m not even talking if you succeed or not; if you want to pray, if you try to order your life to pray, if you try to fast, if you try to be a Christian, if that is what’s important to you from the moment you get up to the moment you put your head on the pillow, then you will conquer your sins, God will help you.

And I’ve seen many times that with people who are beset by sins and they will stay in the same sins, it is a **priority problem.** There is something they are not forsaking. I’m not talking about sin. Sin can be very sweet; it is a sweet poison. And we can desire something very bad for us and be habitually falling into it. That’s not the priority I’m talking about. That’s a weakness of the flesh that God came to help us with. But He will not help us with these weaknesses of the flesh unless we have a mindset that we want to take up our cross and follow Him, no matter what.

Now, maybe you are not ready to confess in the Lord in such a way that you would lose your job. You'd better get ready. You have time right now. The Lord will not expect of you what you cannot do. But He will expect of you what you can become able to do. So if you sit still and have priorities that are basically day-to-day - do this, do that, then when the time comes, you will not be ready. It's all about organizing your life in a certain way.

This is what this Gospel is teaching us. Forsake the things that you can forsake. Perhaps there is a sin that you cannot quite forsake yet. I understand. I've seen a lot of them. I have them myself. But you can order your life as a Christian.

There are a lot of things that you can do to order your priorities.

I'll just give a small example. Perhaps it's a trivial example. Let's say that you are beset by laziness, you come home, and you watch six hours of TV and then fall asleep, not saying your prayers, not reading anything, not doing anything except dissipating yourself, and it happens time and time and time again. All right, here is what you can do. Well, you can get a brick. If you cannot take that brick and put it where it should be put, then you can unsubscribe from cable so that it's a lot harder to see. Or you can make a rule of yourself, I will never, ever copy a TV show on my recorder.

You see, you can show to the Lord that you *want* to fight against a sin. That's just one thing. There are many things. You must forsake things that are not Godly, to become Godly. This is the way.

You know, really, this time of life, right now, that is, the life really in the flesh, it's kind of like, I don't know, in a crude way to put it, it's like a boot camp, you're preparing yourself. And now it's even more important because there really will be battles. There have been in the past. What makes us think that there won't be any coming up?

Really, what has happened in North America has been an anomaly, with the many years of peace to be able to do what we want to. We have people here, Russian, Greek, and others who had members of their families who within the past hundred years died because of righteousness. In many cases the government tried to impose upon them things that they would not allow because of their conscience. They had to make confession. This

has in many cases happened in our lifetime, perhaps across the pond. But it's getting to be a small pond now.

It's going to happen here. I, as your pastor, want you to be ready. Now, that doesn't mean that I want you to stock up on water and buy a shotgun and go off into the woods and be ready for the end. No, I want you to change yourself now and tomorrow and the next day so that you are ready. This is how you become ready; the Gospel tells us: forsake the things that are not Godly. Have the right priorities. Be willing to take up your cross.

Don't think of Christianity as something easy. If you think Christianity is easy, then you have not learned what Christianity is. Christianity is warfare to death. Christianity is violence that wins the Kingdom of Heaven, violence against our passions, and violence against the things that kill us.

So take courage, don't be afraid - Unless you do nothing - Unless you just live complacently. God will help you, if you pray, if you fast, if you struggle, if you forsake the world, and you take up your cross.

One more thing. Maybe you can't do all of it. Okay. **Do some of it.** There's a big mistake in our age. It's like if we can't do it all, we don't do any of it. We are full of sins. Does that mean we shouldn't be righteous too? Absolutely not.

If you don't fast well, perhaps you could fast a little better. If you don't pray very much, perhaps you could pray a little more. If your life is spent in fruitless pursuits, perhaps you could find some way to do something that is good for your soul.

Speak with me. Speak with someone else. Find a way, because the time is coming when you will need to confess with your lips that you are a Christian. And I want you to be ready for it.

Matthew 10:32—33,37-38;19:27-30

Transcribed by the hand of Helen. Priest Seraphim Holland 2010.

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-01_2009-06-14.html

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Sunday of All Saints. "Whosoever therefore shall confess me before men, him will I confess also before my Father which is in heaven"

In the name of the Father and of the Son and the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Today, the Sunday after Pentecost, we remember all of the saints, and we are inspired by these two readings, I would hope, that contain much encouragement. How can one not be encouraged when this whole choir of righteous is enumerated by the apostle Paul, and then he says: "Wherefore seeing we are also compassed about by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight and the sin which doth so easily beset us. Let us run with patience the race that is set before us, looking unto Jesus, the Author and Finisher of our faith, Who, for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame and hath sat down at the right hand of the throne of God."

This should be like an anthem for we Christians. The saints are all described at the end of the Gospel reading. Every righteous one who has ever lived, who has ever pleased God, who has ever struggled with his sins, who has ever truly believed in the resurrection is described today because our Lord says: "Everyone that hath forsaken houses, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children or lands for My Name's sake, shall receive a hundredfold and shall inherit everlasting life. But many that are first shall be last, and the last shall be first."

This describes in microcosm the life that pleases God, the life that we are called to. We are to forsake that which weighs us down, sin which easily besets us, and even father or mother or sister or brother, if they weigh us down, if they keep us from the kingdom of God.

In most cases, that would not be literally necessary; Jesus Christ is not telling us always to leave our father and mother. Indeed we must love them and honor them, whether they honor God or not. But it is a value judgment here; it is a set of priorities. If we are to inherit what is our birthright, then we must live according to that birthright. You remember, with Esau and Jacob, Esau had the birthright, but he didn't live according to it, so it was taken from him.

These readings contain not only the encouragement and this incredible joy that we should feel about the grace of God; they also have a blueprint, a path of how to live. Not only how to live, but also how *not* to live. The promise is there, that also contains very clearly for those who have ears to hear and eyes to see, what happens when a man does not follow Christ.

Now, this is the Sunday after Pentecost. Pentecost, the out-pouring of the Holy Spirit, the gift of the Holy Spirit upon all in the church, is what makes us capable of being part of this choir of the saints. It's what helps *all* men to attain the knowledge of God and righteousness.

St. Paul says "through faith" they did this, "through faith" they did that. This was in the Old Testament times, before the giving of the Holy Spirit. Even more remarkable are the exploits of the saints before the coming of Christ, because the Holy Spirit did not dwell within them. The Holy Spirit influenced their lives, guided them, helped them, but did not dwell within them. This was meant for a later time. And St. Paul alludes to this when he says: "And these all, having obtained a good report through faith, received

not the promise, God having provided some better thing for us, that they without us should not be made perfect."

He is pointing to the coming of the God-man Jesus Christ, and then the bringing of the Holy Spirit after Jesus Christ showed and in actuality did what was necessary for our salvation. He showed us how to live, and lived according to His commandments, and caused Himself to rise from the dead. And then the bringing of the Holy Spirit enlightens us, strengthens us, and allows us to do the will of God and to obtain the promise.

I want to focus on some things that were said in the Gospel - the Gospel is a composite reading, by the way. It is actually Matthew chapter ten and also a portion of chapter nineteen. It fits together very nicely in context, and that's why the Holy Spirit must have desired the reading be put together as it was for this day. Our Lord said: "Whosoever therefore shall confess me before men, him will I confess also before my Father which is in heaven."

This is a fundamental characteristic of righteousness, to confess the Lord Jesus Christ. And how do we confess Him? With our lips and with our actions; with our priorities and with our way of dealing with people, with what we say is important and what we show is important.

There are some obvious things that you could have come to mind. We confess the Lord by showing that we care about Christianity, that we live our lives in a moral way. The entire world has gone off unto Sodom and Gomorrah, but we cannot do this. We must have the courage to stand against it, to stand against every form of immorality and vice. This is the confession of Christ.

Now there is a new form of Christianity in name only. It's been around now for quite a good many years. You really can see the beginnings of it in Apostolic times, but certainly, in the past few hundred years of the post-enlightenment age, it has been codified that this is an acceptable way of life.

This way of life confesses Christ with the lips, but not with action, not with morality, not with the way we live, not with the way we order our lives. The new Christianity, from which the Orthodox are not immune, has a dichotomy between belief and action. But there is no such thing. This is the great lie. Faith without works is dead. There is no dichotomy between action and belief. And if you do not live according to what you say you believe, you are not confessing Christ. And we've been given everything we need to confess Him. We've been given the Holy Spirit, the Comforter, Who lives within us if indeed we make a place for Him, if indeed we clean out our soul, and garnish it and sweep it out with effort and desire. And He will help us in all things. But if we do not live righteously, we are not confessing Christ.

Christ says He will confess us before His Father if we live according to His will and confess Him in this life. But He won't confess us before His Father if we do not live in such a way. For those people who do not live in such a way are reserved the words, "I don't know you. I don't know who you are. You have no part with Me. You haven't become like Me. Go away. Go unto outer darkness."²² Those words are reserved for those people who confess with their lips but not with the way they live, not with their priorities.

Now there are other practical things. In our modern society, we are constantly in social situations. Are you afraid to make the sign of the cross before you have your dinner in a restaurant? If this is the case, you should weep and lament and pound your breast and ask God's forgiveness for this, and do it the next time. Are you afraid among your friends or among your business associates or whomever else you come across in your daily walk of life to show your priorities and the Christian way of thinking, or do you change your priorities based upon the vicissitudes of your life, maybe so you are not in trouble, or so nobody thinks badly of you, or maybe just so that you are not inconvenienced?

This is not confessing Christ, either. This is confessing the Devil because this is the way the Devil wants us to live. The Devil is perfectly happy with lipservice to Christianity; he loves that. In fact, I think he prefers it to out and out paganism because what does our Lord say to those in the church of Laodicea, in Revelations? "Thou art lukewarm, and I will spit thee out of my mouth."

No, brothers and sisters, we are not to be lukewarm. We have fire within us. The Holy Spirit warms us. That fire should burn things, not burn us; it should burn the sins within us, and it should glow. There should be a light. People should see it.

I am convinced there are two main reasons our churches are not full - one is the world is very evil, and people are not interested in a Christian way of life. They are interested in Christian lipservice, but not in actually ordering their lives completely according to Christ. That's part of it. But another part of it is, we don't shine. We don't profess Christ in every aspect of how we live, how we think, and prioritize. Every single person in our workplace should notice something about us, or think we're different. Some may hate us because it - absolutely and positively. Some hated Christ. But there was no one that encountered Christ that did not notice something about Him, that did not have to come to a decision because of Him. So should it be with us.

We must confess Christ before men. Don't live your life according to the priorities of the world. Don't let anything get in the way of an all-out assault on your passions and an all-out desire to follow the commandments. We have this cloud of witnesses. Look what they did: through faith, they subdued kingdoms, they wrought righteousness, they obtained promises, they stopped the mouths of lions, they were sawn asunder, they wandered about in sheep skins and in goat skins. The world was not even worthy of them. All of these things were struggles. None of these things that I just mentioned are pleasant. All of them were difficult trials. The Christian life is indeed a trial, a difficulty, it is an arena, it is a life-or-death struggle.

If this causes your heart to contract and be afraid, then you must beg the Holy Spirit to indwell in you more and be joyful on this day that so many have entered into the kingdom of heaven, so many have endured struggles, and pain, and grief, and endured to the end, and come to the kingdom of heaven.

And they are all examples for us, all around. And they are proof that the resurrection is real. The resurrection is true. And it changes a man. This news is the best news that can be said. There is nothing greater. The resurrection changes us! Now our life sometimes is filled with bitterness and difficulty. Some of it is from without, brought on by those whom we know, or whom we don't know. Some of it is from within, from our own sinfulness, our lack of belief, our lack of constancy, our lack of good priorities. But regardless, life is struggle. Everyone understands this. But God has given us the tools to endure in the struggle.

God has given us everything we need, and on this day we celebrate the whole panoply of saints that have endured to the end, as an example to us, but also - we must understand, and we must be able to have these two thoughts together at the same time - also as a reproach against us. They are both a reproach against us and also an encouragement to us, both at the same time, because they've all endured. They're made of the same stuff as we are. They had the same difficulties with sins that we have. They were given the same grace that we have been given, the same truth, the same God, the same Holy Spirit. But they fought the good fight and endured; they finished the course.

And now we ask their intercessions before God, for our sinful selves. We can attain; we *must* attain some measure of what they have attained. We are called to perfection. **Christianity is not just a belief system, or membership; it is the continual, extreme change of a man.** And this is good news. There is so much wrong with us, so much incomplete, so much

that hurts, so much that is imperfect, so much that we don't know, so much that makes us sad; *all of that* God will change. No sadness, no incompleteness, no sickness, no bad thoughts, nothing whatsoever that causes our faces to be downcast, but instead all light.

This is what God wants to give us. We must live our life according to this promise, aim for this promise, and struggle for this promise. Then we will truly be called friend by our Lord. He will call us friends, and we will be able to cry, "Abba, Father." Such incredible intimacy with God! The saints obtained it. And we can attain it. But only by struggle, only by confessing Christ, only by living according to His commandments.

In the middle of today's reading it says, "He that taketh not up his cross and followeth after me, the same is not worthy of Me." We must struggle according to what He has told us to do. I am continually struck by the lives of the saints, and by the writings of the fathers, by how these two thoughts - our depravity and God's great mercy - are welded into one. On almost every page of the Scriptures this knowledge of the condition of man, which

is deplorable, and the promise of what man will become, is present. And we see it in the saints. We see their righteousness, how God brought them home. We also see their struggles, and we should compare their struggles to our own, and mix always the knowledge of what God has predestined for us with the knowledge of what kind of person we are. They always must be mixed together. And then we will struggle.

We will push on, and we will fight, and we will finish the course. The Holy Spirit has made it possible for us. The Holy Spirit enlightens us, and lives within us if we live according to His commandments. May God help you to confess Christ in everything you say and everything you do, in how you prioritize, and live your life. Amen.

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Pentecost. Short exegesis on the Holy Spirit How to listen to the Holy Spirit when He talks to the heart.

SYNOPSIS: A short catechesis on the Holy Spirit, covering His procession from the Father, the various symbols for the Holy Spirit, the important scripture text which tells us not to "quench the Spirit", and about blasphemy against the Holy Spirit. Then we get to the best part, the best a pastor has to give his flock. We discuss how the Holy Spirit communicates with us, and how to listen to and "feel" our heart, and this "understanding that is within us" will teach us all things, and guide and help us in everything. We must learn to know when our heart is cold, or warm, enlarged or shriveled up, soft or hard. This is a skill which we must learn; we can speak a little bit about it, but only God can teach us.

In the Name of The Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. Amen. Today is a great and holy day. It is very difficult to speak about it in a sermon from the Scriptures because the Scriptures that describe the coming of the Holy Spirit are only the beginning. They only describe the event, but the Holy Spirit truly gives us Life. Without the Holy Spirit, we would have no Life, no Knowledge of God. We would not be able to do one good thing. So we should understand a little bit about the Holy Spirit.

I thought what I would do today is sort of a little catechetical primer on the Holy Spirit. Certainly, I will not cover everything, and certainly, it will be a little bit eclectic because I'm a little bit eclectic. After that, I want to tell you the most important thing that I know how to tell you as a pastor about the Holy Spirit. It is the most practical thing, but it's not an easy thing; it's not a kind of thing such that you can just follow directions and you can have it happen, like baking a cake. But it is the most important thing that I can tell you about the Holy Spirit.

It's a skill that you can learn if you try to learn it, because I've learned it a *little bit*. And the more I read from the Neptic Fathers that I've been reading lately, the more I realize how little I've learned. But indeed, I've learned a little, and I'll tell you what I've learned.

So, let's talk about the Holy Spirit. Let's start at the beginning, the *non-beginning* beginning, when **God was**, and there was nothing else. The Holy Trinity has revealed Himself to us: He is Father without beginning, and the Father has a Son Who is eternally begotten of The Father, so His *beginningless* beginning is in The Father, but before all things. And the Holy Spirit proceeds from The Father.

Now there are examples, but we won't go into them right now, things about a sun or a river, things that can give you some understanding of the Holy Trinity. What we need to know about the Holy Trinity is that we don't know anything about the Holy Trinity **unless He reveals Himself to us, and also unless we are able to receive what He reveals.**

God is a manifest fact. **He is the only fact in the universe.** He is the only thing in the universe, if you can call God a thing, that is **alive in and of**

itself. Everything else is alive because He chooses for it to be alive. If He removes His Hand, it would instantly not only not be alive, but wink out of existence entirely. So God's Hand is upon all things, even upon those things we call dead because they have not ceased to exist.

And the Holy Spirit is an equal, not part of God - that's the wrong way to say it because God is not in parts - God is simple and undivided - He is an equal hypostasis of God, an equal Person, if you will, of God. God is three Persons undivided, equal in their Godhead, differing with each other in only one way that has been revealed to us and we don't even understand that. And that is that God the Father is Father, He is Father of the Son who was eternally begotten of Him for all ages, not created, not made, and the Holy Spirit proceeds from Him eternally.

And that is **all** we understand about the Holy Trinity in terms of facts about Him. And the only way we learn about the Holy Trinity is to **become like Him**. There's no "book learning" that you can have to understand the Holy Trinity. You can read about the Orthodox Faith from St. John Damascene, and you can understand a few things, certain terminology. You can read St. Basil the Great, but to understand the Holy Spirit, you have to become like Him. To understand the Holy Trinity, you have to become like Him.

Let's talk about some symbols of the Holy Spirit and a little bit about what is said in the Scripture about Him. In the account that we heard today²³, the Holy Spirit was manifested first in a rushing, mighty wind and then in tongues of fire that set upon each of the disciples' heads. Those are two of the symbols of the Holy Spirit.

Fire: because the Holy Spirit cleanses and illuminates. But He also burns. He also roots out passion.

Wind: because, according to our Lord, the Holy Spirit is like the wind that goes where it wills²⁴. When He was speaking of Nicodemus, He was speaking of this. The Holy Spirit goes where He wills. He can go anywhere He wants. And in fact, He is everywhere that He wants to be all at the same time. Just as we don't understand the wind, why the wind goes here and then there, so we do not know why the Holy Spirit goes here and then there, and is everywhere, and He manifests to some and not to others, and some understand Him, and some do not.

The Holy Spirit is also symbolized by water. The Lord said, in fact, we have the account of it today²⁵, that out of His belly shall flow forth rivers of living water. That's speaking of The Spirit. Water also cleanses. Water gives life, and without water, there is no life on earth. The Holy Spirit gives life.

He is also symbolized by the cloud. During the procession of the Jews, that long procession of forty years because of their disobedience (it's only a two-week trip, by the way), the cloud by day would show them where to

go.²⁶ That was the Holy Spirit. Also, the fire by night was the Holy Spirit showing them the way. And also, when Jesus was on Mt. Tabor with His three disciples and showed Himself as He really is with the uncreated Light streaming from Him, the cloud came over them. And the cloud is the Holy Spirit.

Now, physically, a cloud is not the Holy Spirit; it's a symbol. What do clouds do? If you've been flying in an airplane and you go through a cloud, you're completely enveloped by the cloud. You see nothing else but cloud. It fills all things. It is present everywhere. That is how the Holy Spirit is like a cloud.

We also symbolize the Holy Spirit by the dove²⁷. A dove is a pure bird, it would not soil its nesting space, and it's a clean bird. And, of course, white has always been a symbol of purity.

These are the major symbols of the Holy Spirit.

I want to talk about a couple of things that the Scripture says and explain them, and then we will get to the most important part. So, if you feel a little bit sleepy and bored, be sleepy and bored for the next couple of minutes and then wake up because I'm going to tell you the most essential part in a couple of minutes. It's the hardest part to explain, too, but we'll see how we do.

The Scripture tells us to **"quench not the Spirit."**²⁸ What does this mean? The Holy Spirit abides in us and enlightens us in all things. Anything good that you do is because the Holy Spirit has enlightened you and aided you. If you do anything bad the Holy Spirit will enlighten you, if you will listen, about your sin. Quenching the Spirit is to *not listen* to the Holy Spirit. It is to do according to our own will and not according to His. That is the way of death. When we sin, there are always signs that we have sinned. I'll talk about those a little bit later because that's really the most important part

There is a term in the Scriptures that many people do not understand: *"Blasphemy against the Holy Spirit."*²⁹ Some think that it is to commit suicide since this sin would be the last earthly act of a person. That's not blasphemy against the Holy Spirit.

Blasphemy against the Holy Spirit is to **resist the Holy Spirit throughout your life**. It is not to repent. We're all in danger of committing blasphemy against the Holy Spirit. We should all fear that sin. We should always repent of the things we do, or actually, not so much the things we do as *who we are*. You should repent of who you are. You should be a better person than you are. **That's the whole point of being a Christian; you should become better** because we're going to be in the presence of the Best. And that which is impure cannot bear being in the presence of Purity.

So the blasphemy against the Holy Spirit is to not repent throughout your life. At what point has the person committed blasphemy against the Holy Spirit? God knows this. I've known people that I don't think will ever repent. I think they've already committed blasphemy against the Holy Spirit. I can see this sometimes in their eyes. There's no life in their eyes. And they're going to live the rest of their life as a shell, no longer really as a human being because they have hardened their heart against God.

But even a person who appears to have done this can find their way, sometimes through terrible means that expose their sin. So the only One Who knows if a person has committed blasphemy against the Holy Spirit is God. And the only time that determination is made is after their death because God waits until the end of life for someone to repent.

Now let's talk about the most important part, the pastoral part that I wish to impart to you. It has to do with the command to **"Quench not the Holy Spirit."** It also has to do with the **purpose of life** as defined by my patron, St. Seraphim. Do you remember what he said? He says the purpose of life is the **acquisition of the Holy Spirit**³⁰. So all of your life, you should be acquiring, much like a trader would acquire. You should acquire much like a miser who wants more and more money would acquire. You should want more and more of The Spirit.

And how do you acquire the Holy Spirit? **You take on His attributes**. We know many of His attributes; they're described in the Scriptures and by the symbols we mentioned and also by the prayer, *"O Heavenly King."*³¹ So let's look at that quickly and understand some of the things we must do to acquire the Holy Spirit.

"O Heavenly King, Comforter, Spirit of Truth." We must live honestly, not just by telling the truth to people when they ask us something, but an *internal honesty with ourselves and with God*. That's the most challenging honesty. It's enough to be able to tell the truth to yourself. And The Spirit of Truth will help you to be able to tell the truth to yourself.

We say, *"Who art everywhere present and fillest all things."* So we should become everywhere present and filling all things. We can't do that as the Holy Spirit does. But everywhere we are, whatever we are doing, there is only one important thing on our agenda: To live as a Christian, to love our brother, to be like God. That is what I mean by being everywhere present. **It is being always in the moment of living according to God**. That's a hard thing, but it can be accomplished even in this world.

And then the rest of this prayer says, *"Come and abide in us, cleanse us of all our impurities and save our souls, O Good One."* I want to say something about the last part of that prayer in a moment³² because the need for the last part of the prayer should eventually disappear.

So, how do you acquire the Holy Spirit? *By thinking spiritually*. The Lord said to Nicodemus that that which is born of flesh is flesh, and that which is born of Spirit is Spirit.³³ He's teaching a very important thing: to learn to live spiritually and see the truth of everything, the **Actual Truth**, not the appearance of truth, but the essence of what everything is. Thinking spiritually tells us if something is good or is bad. And the only way to know the essence of something is to think spiritually. It is to have the Holy Spirit enlightening you in words that cannot be uttered in any language because the Holy Spirit speaks to the heart.

How do you listen to the Holy Spirit? **My attempt to answer this question is the best I can give you as a pastor; it is the most important thing I can say to you**. As I said, there is no instruction manual for this. But it is the most important thing to learn.

You must learn to listen to your heart. You must learn to feel your heart as much as if it was out of your chest and pumping in your hands. It's every rhythm. It's every move. Now I'm not speaking of the physical organ. I'm speaking of the Holy Spirit communicating with your soul, whose seat is the heart. **You must learn to look into your heart for everything you do. That's your first evaluation of whether something is good or bad**.

So, when you encounter a situation, you should be able to look into your heart. You should feel your heart.

You should know

if your heart is hot or if it is cold,

if it's soft or if it is like stone,

if it is dark or if it is light.

You should feel the perturbations in your heart. That is the Holy Spirit speaking to you³⁴. That's the most essential skill you can learn. And that skill can only be learned if you really pay attention. It's the only way to learn it. You must be focused on it. In your daily life, you should always be listening to your heart because your heart is being spoken to by the Holy Spirit. And it will tell you everything you need to know.

There is one prayer, in the Presanctified Liturgy, it's a prayer that a priest says privately, and he mentions "the understanding that which is in us"³⁵. This is not something that is sort of a 'new agey' sort of thing that people believe in, as if we have some kind of wisdom from some collective consciousness. That's all a bunch of malarkey. The *understanding that is within us* is the Holy Spirit enlightening us, and you must listen closely to hear it.

A good friend of mine once said something and it applies well here: "You can't hear a conversation with someone when there's a train rushing

through your head.”³⁶ I used to go walking on the railroad tracks on a certain job when I had lunch, and I wasn’t that smart. Sometimes I would stand very close as the train would go by. It was unbelievably loud. The engineer didn’t like it; he would blow his horn at me. A train is unbelievably loud when you’re standing near it. If there’s a train going through your head, you don’t hear anything.

And if there’s a train going through our heads, that’s *our false motivations, our bad attitudes, our laziness, our unspiritual way of looking at things, our shallow way of living*. That’s the train. And you can’t hear the Spirit if you’ve got that train.

Remember when Elias heard God and knew God was present?³⁷ It wasn’t in the earthquake or the flood or the fire. It was in that little still wind. You can’t hear a still wind unless you’re quiet. So he was standing quietly and God was Present. *You must learn to be quiet to hear God*.

I’m not talking about being quiet by not speaking. I’m not talking about being quiet by quitting your job and moving off to a mountain. **I’m talking about being quiet by listening to your heart.** You can be quiet in the midst of the city and you can be very loud in the desert. We must listen to our heart. And that is where the Holy Spirit speaks to us.

Try this. Some of you may not understand what I am telling you. I’m telling you the most important thing I can say to you because it’s the way to have life. It’s the way to have water springing up from the belly, that Living Water that refreshes everything and gives life to everything. *Everything we do, we must look at spiritually*. There is nothing that we do that we should not look at spiritually. If you cannot look at something spiritually, it’s a good sign you shouldn’t be doing it.

So learn to look into your heart. As I said to you, I can’t explain to you how to do this. Only God can explain to you how to do this. But you must focus on this, desire this. That’s basically what the prayer, “O Heavenly King,” is saying. “Come and abide in us, cleanse us of all impurities and save our souls.” We’re asking God, the Holy Spirit, to fill us, envelop us and lead us in everything we do.

We are much like a child who is constantly checking with his mother or father. Is this right? Is this okay? Is this person safe? That’s what children who have parents that are reliable do. They’re always checking with their parents. You can see that today, in the infants today. We should be like that. Everything that we do, we should be looking backward to the Holy Spirit. Is this alright? Is this what I should do? Is this how I should think? Is this how I should be? Is this the person I’m supposed to be? Or, is this wrong? The Holy Spirit will tell you through your heart. Your heart will feel cold, or your heart will feel warm.

I think every single one of us has had some conflict with a person. I want to give you a concrete example. Unless there is a saint among us that is invisible to our eyes, every one of us has had some conflict with a person, somebody we just don’t like very well. They haven’t treated us well. They’re a braggart, or they’re unkind, or they’re a loud mouth, and we just don’t like them that much.

When we see them, and they enter the room, our heart will tell us how we feel about them. Our heart will tell us when there’s a darkening or if

there’s coldness. That’s a sign of sin. That’s a sign of judgment, or jealousy, or of anger, or of remembering wrongs, or maybe of all of those things. The heart will tell you. All of us have experienced this. Perhaps someone has wronged us from years ago. If we think that we’re over from what was done or that we have forgiven that person, then we find out that that person has remarried or has gotten a great job or some other such thing. What does our heart tell us then? If our heart is glad for them, if our heart is warm and enlarged, then we know that we have repented of our sin. We no longer judge them; we no longer have any bitterness. But if our heart constricts, feels smaller, and shriveled up like a prune, then we know that we have not yet forgiven them. And we are still filled with bitterness.

This example can be used in any other area of life. The basic principles to listen to your heart not so much with your ear, but you feel it. You feel whether your heart is warm or cold, whether it is soft or hard as rock, whether or not it is enlarged or whether or not it shriveled, whether or not it’s light or it’s dark. Evaluate your heart because the Holy Spirit is speaking to your heart.

As I said, this is the best I can give you; it is the most important thing I can tell you because this is the Way of Life. May God help us to be filled with the Holy Spirit and to hear Him. Amen.

(*At the conclusion of The Divine Liturgy*) I wanted to add one thing that I forgot to say in the sermon. And that is, I told you that at the ending part of the prayer, “O Heavenly King,” Where it says, “Cleanse us of all our iniquities,” that part of the prayer we won’t say forever because when we are in the presence of God, we won’t have any need to say that anymore. We will be abiding in Him and He in us.

So, the Scripture, I was asking Reader David, there’s a Scripture that basically more or less says that in somewhat of a dark way, where The Lord asks us actually to stop praying. You know there’s a place where The Lord Jesus Christ actually tells us to stop praying. Did you know that?

It does not contradict what Paul says, which is “pray without ceasing.” I couldn’t find the reference, but He says at that time, basically you are to stop praying. You stop asking when you have what you ask for.

So we continue to say, “O Heavenly King, Comforter, Spirit of Truth, who art everywhere present and fillest all things. Come and abide in us and cleanse us of all impurities and save our souls, O Good One.” We say this prayer because He does *not completely abide in us yet* nor are we completely pure yet. But there will come a time when He will completely abide in us. And at that time, we will no longer say that prayer. That’ll be in the next age. Slava Bogyi! (Glory be to God)

Priest Seraphim Holland 2015

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-00_2015-05-31+exegesis-on-the-holy-spirit+how-to-listen-to-your-heart.html

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ANSWERS to: Questions about Pentecost

ANSWER 0: The Second Ecumenical Council, in Constantinople, wrote the last 4 articles of the Symbol of Faith.

ANSWER 1: The ministry of the Holy Spirit was carefully described by Christ shortly before His death and resurrection, and after He rose from the dead, until His glorious Ascension. Some of His teaching was preserved in the Holy Scriptures, although not all³⁸, but all of His teaching has been faithfully preserved by the church. The service of Pentecost, and the Sunday matins Hymns of Ascents³⁹ especially explain the “economy” of the Holy Spirit, but this teaching is contained in many services and the writings of the Fathers.

The Holy Spirit reveals truth to a man, enlightens him, and purifies him with fire. The Holy Spirit, Who guides into all truth, reveals the mystical dogmas of Christ and the Holy Trinity. By the Holy Spirit, the prophets prophesied, the apostles taught, and the councils of the church defined the divine dogmas concerning the All-Holy Trinity, and other things in the life in the church. By the Holy Spirit, the weak were made strong, and the faint-hearted brave, and seeing the things of God, are made able to endure grievous martyrdoms. By the Holy Spirit, ordinary bread and wine are changed into the body and blood of Christ. By the Holy Spirit, a man has his sin revealed and has the means to change. By the Holy Spirit, the simple are

made wise. By the Holy Spirit, a man sees things that cannot even be uttered, the deep things of God, after the Spirit prepares him. By the Holy Spirit, a man prays in spirit and truth, according to his need and the will of God. By the Holy Spirit, the Christian life is lived.

"And I will pray the Father, and he shall give you another Comforter, that he may abide with you for ever; {17} Even the Spirit of truth; whom the world cannot receive, because it seeth him not, neither knoweth him: but ye know him; for he dwelleth with you, and shall be in you." (John 14:16-17)

"But the Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost, whom the Father will send in my name, he shall teach you all things, and bring all things to your remembrance, whatsoever I have said unto you." (John 14:26)

"But when the Comforter is come, whom I will send unto you from the Father, even the Spirit of truth, which proceedeth from the Father, he shall testify of me:" (John 15:26)

"Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth: for he shall not speak of himself; but whatsoever he shall hear, that shall he speak: and he will show you things to come. {14} He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall show it unto you." (John 16:13-14)

"But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth." (Acts 1:8)

"But as it is written, Eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, neither have entered into the heart of man, the things which God hath prepared for them that love him. {10} But God hath revealed them unto us by his Spirit: for the Spirit searcheth all things, yea, the deep things of God. {11} For what man knoweth the things of a man, save the spirit of man which is in him? even so the things of God knoweth no man, but the Spirit of God. {12} Now we have received, not the spirit of the world, but the spirit which is of God; that we might know the things that are freely given to us of God. {13} Which things also we speak, not in the words which man's wisdom teacheth, but which the Holy Ghost teacheth; comparing spiritual things with spiritual." (1 Cor 2:9-13)

"The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God: {17} And if children, then heirs; heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ; if so be that we suffer with him, that we may be also glorified together. {26} Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered." (Rom 8:16-26)

"The Holy Spirit provideth all things; He gusheth forth prophecy; He perfecteth the priesthood; He hath taught wisdom to the illiterate. He hath shown forth the fishermen as theologians. He holdeth together the whole institution of the Church. Wherefore, O Comforter, one in essence and throne with the Father and the Son, glory be to Thee." (Pentecost Vespers, Lord I have cried, 3rd Sticheron)

"O Heavenly King, Comforter, Spirit of Truth, Who art everywhere present and fillest all things, Treasury of good things and Giver of life: Come and dwell in us, and cleanse us of all impurity, and save, our souls, O Good One." (Pentecost Vespers, the third sticheron of the Aposticha, and numerous other places)

"The Holy Spirit is Light and Life, and a living, noetic Fountain, a Spirit of wisdom, a Spirit of understanding; a good, an upright, a noetic Spirit, presiding in power and purging offenses. He is God, and doth deify; He is Fire, issuing from Fire, speaking, working, distributing the gifts; through Whom all the Prophets, and the Apostles of God, and all the Martyrs received their crowns. Strange is this report, strange and new this sight, a Fire divided that these gifts may be apportioned." (Pentecost Matins, Third sticheron at the Praises)

The Sunday matins service is indispensable for the proper understanding of the ministry and action of the Holy Spirit, especially the 3 part Hymns of Ascents (4 parts if in the eighth tone), which impress the soul profoundly with their deep theology sung to sweet melody. Unfortunately, the overwhelming majority of the Orthodox never or almost

never hear these beautiful hymns, which occur in the middle of matins. Perhaps 4 things can occur in reference to Sunday matins, and 3 of them are bad. In a shocking number of churches, matins is not even served, or is served in a severely truncated manner, either out of the spirit of ecumenism, ignorance, laziness or indifference to the divine law of God. Many do not attend vigil as a rule, or the morning orthos, or they leave God's house early, or come late. In the best of circumstances, the holy services are served completely and piously, and the faithful Christian considers his time these services to be more important than any agenda, or schedule, or worldly priority.

"By the Holy Spirit is every soul given life, exalted by purity, and made radiant by the unity of the Trinity in a sacred and mystical manner." (Sunday Octoechos, the Hymns of Ascent, Tone 2)

ANSWER 2. Dove, wind, cloud, water, fire.

Dove. At the Theophany of the Lord (His baptism) the Holy Spirit appeared as a dove. This symbol has been used iconographically from the earliest times. At Pentecost, He appeared as tongues of fire. He was also manifested by the mighty wind, and by the Apostles speaking in Tongues.

"And Jesus, when he was baptized, went up straightway out of the water: and, lo, the heavens were opened unto him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove, and lighting upon him" (Mat 3:16)

Wind and Fire. "And when the day of Pentecost was fully come, they were all with one accord in one place. {2} And suddenly there came a sound from heaven as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled all the house where they were sitting. {3} And there appeared unto them cloven tongues like as of fire, and it sat upon each of them. {4} And they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance." (Acts 2:1-4)

"Coming down to those on earth, the Holy Spirit's spring was seen in the form of fiery streams apportioned spiritually to all, as it bedewed and enlightened the Lord's Apostles. And thus, the fire became a cloud bedewing them, filling them with light, and raining flames on them. And through them, grace hath been vouchsafed us by fire and water in very truth. Behold, the Comforter's light is come and hath illumined the whole world." (Pentecost Matins, Sessional hymn after the 2nd reading from the Psalter)

"That is the reason why the Holy Spirit comes in the form of a dove: it is a simple joyous creature, not bitter with gall, not biting savagely, without vicious rearing claws; it loves to dwell with humankind, it keeps to one house for assembling; when they mate they hatch their young together, when they fly anywhere they keep their formulation, the resorts they live in are shared in common, by their billing too they pay tribute to concord and peace, in all things they fulfil the law of unanimity. The same is the simplicity of the Church which we need to learn, this is the charity we must acquire, that we may imitate the doves in our love for the brethren, and rival lambs and sheep in their meekness and gentleness." St. Cyprian, The Unity of the Catholic Church

ANSWER 3 The Most common prayer to the Holy spirit is "O Heavenly King":

"O Heavenly King, Comforter, Spirit of Truth, Who art everywhere present and fillest all things, Treasury of good things and Giver of life: Come and dwell in us, and cleanse us of all impurity, and save, our souls, O Good One."

This prayer is at the beginning of many services⁴⁰, as the start of the Trisagion prayers, which, although simple and oft repeated, contain a profundity of theology.

The Trisagion prayers are as follows:

O Heavenly King...

Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal, have mercy on us. (*Thrice*)

Glory to the Father, and to the Son, and to the Holy Spirit, both now and ever, and unto the unto the ages of ages. Amen.

O Most Holy Trinity, have mercy on us. O Lord, blot out our sins. O Master, pardon our iniquities. O Holy One, visit and heal our infirmities for Thy name's sake.

Lord have mercy. (*Thrice*)

Glory to the Father and to the Son and to the Holy Spirit, both now and ever, and unto the ages of ages. Amen.

Our Father, Who art in the Heavens, hallowed by Thy Name. Thy Kingdom come, Thy will be done, on earth as it is in Heaven. Give us this day our daily bread. And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from the evil one.

Priest: For Thine is the Kingdom and the power and the glory, of the Father, and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, now and ever, and unto the ages of ages.

A layman "Through the prayers of our holy Fathers, O Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on us. Amen".

These prayers are in: Morning prayers, Evening prayers, Midnight Office, Daily matins, The 3rd and 9th hour, Daily vespers, Compline.

This prayer also is often used before the beginning of any work, Or before instruction, and is in several "trebnic" services.

The prayer is not said "aloud" in divine liturgy, but the Priest prays it silently (in a quiet, usually almost inaudible voice) just before liturgy begins.

"Heavenly King" is omitted in all prayers and services from Pascha until the Vigil for Pentecost.

ANSWER 4 The Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father. This is a divinely revealed dogma, first expressed exactly by Jesus Christ Himself, when he said

"But when the Comforter is come, whom I will send unto you from the Father, even the Spirit of truth, which proceedeth from the Father, he shall testify of me" (John 15:26)

This dogma was later formalized in the Symbol of Faith, in the Second Ecumenical council, with the following article concerning the Holy Spirit: "And in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the Giver of life; Who proceedeth from the Father; Who with the Father and the Son together is worshipped and glorified; Who spake by the prophets."

Belief in this dogma is obligatory. Those who add "and from the son" (the Filioque) sin against the words of Christ Himself, and the divinely revealed dogmas of the church, and those who persist in this heresy are outside of the church. There is no room for compromise concerning this dogma, especially since the councils themselves forbade any change to the symbol of faith. In our age, dogma is passe, and there is a rush for unity in organization, and mutual "acceptance" of one another's beliefs, whether they be the revealed beliefs of the Christian faith or not. Therefore, the dispute over the Filioque is thought to be a mere "misunderstanding" over terminology, but the Orthodox, who hear in their services this dogma expressed with startling clarity, and read the lives of Saints who endured exile for this dogma, believe it without wavering.

"Proceeds:" this is the only use of this word in the entire Bible.

History – introduction in Spain, patronized by Frankish kings, Roman resistance, Pope Leo's silver tablets, later introduced more broadly as part of both expanding Frankish power and consolidation of papal power. "Anything about God is a big deal because it affects our relationship with Him, and we have a relational faith."

Non-scriptural, arguments for it rely on reason. We however accept truth based on revelation and are faithful to our Lord's words.

Introduced in contradiction to the councils

Conflates His Eternal Being with His temporal mission (connected to the heresy of Barlaam, that we can know nothing of Him at all)

Against the Orthodox understanding that the Father is the source and principle of the Godhead.

Demotes the Holy Spirit by introduces a quality (source of procession) held in common by 2 persons of the Trinity and not the 3rd.

Interestingly, the West currently (I don't know the history of this) recognizes that the Greek work "proceeds" in the Creed can refer only to the Father, and so in Greek they don't use the filioque clause. But in Latin they use it, since that the Latin "procedit" has a slightly different meaning that can accommodate the Son as well.

Some argue that the filioque heresy lies at the root of all problems in the Western church. This, if true, would be another example of the far-reaching implications of dogma.

ANSWER 5. On the first Christian Pentecost, the Apostles spoke, and people understood their preaching in their own tongues. It is not entirely clear whether the gift was in the "speaking" or in the "hearing", but the result was that all men heard the gospel (good tidings) in their own tongue. The apostles did not speak in an ecstatic prayer language, as the modern day heretical Pentecostal sects, and other Protestants and Roman Catholics infected with this false teaching practice.

ANSWER 6. On the day of Pentecost, the disciples were gathered in the upper room, praying. Suddenly, there was a sound, like a mighty wind, and the Holy Spirit descended on each of them in the form of tongues of fire. This fire was not the Holy Spirit, but a symbol of His presence. They Apostles were able to preach the gospel and be understood by each man in his own tongue.

ANSWER 7. In Psalm 50, the Holy Prophet and King David, who had, as a man, fallen into grievous adultery and murder, prayed "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me. Cast me not away from Thy presence, and take not Thy Holy Spirit from me. Restore unto me the joy of Thy salvation, and with Thy governing Spirit establish me." We must understand that we can lose the Holy Spirit by sinning, and not repenting. The church services are full of advice in this regard.

ANSWER 8. Chrismation confers the gift of the Holy Spirit upon the newly baptized Christian.

It is the clear teaching of the church that the Holy Spirit can be lost because of unrepentant sin. Why else would the Prophet David, in his repentant psalm (50) which he prayed after he realized the full weight of his guilt for the murder of Urias, the husband of Bathsheba, whom he had committed adultery with say: "Cast me not away from Thy presence, and take not Thy Holy Spirit from me"?

"The Spirit does not take up His abode in someone's life through a physical approach; how could a corporeal being approach the Bodiless one? Instead, the Spirit comes to us when we withdraw ourselves from evil passions, which have crept into the soul through its friendship with the flesh, alienating us from a close relationship with God. Only when a man has been cleansed from the shame of his evil, and has returned to his natural beauty, and the original form of the Royal Image has been restored in him, is it possible for him to approach the Paraclete. Then, like the sun, He will show you in Himself the image of the invisible, and with purified eyes you will see in this blessed image the unspeakable beauty of its prototype." St. Basil the Great, On the Holy Spirit.

ANSWER 9. The giving of the Holy Spirit occurred fifty days after the resurrection. In Greek "Pentekoste" means "Fiftieth Day". This was also during the Jewish feast called "Pentecost", which celebrated the giving of the law. Only through the Holy Spirit may we actually fulfil the law. The Holy Spirit reveals the law to our hearts.

ANSWER 10 Pentecost is a "Great Feast" of the Lord, and supersedes the Sunday Octoechos, which is usually the primary commemoration on Sunday. On the eve of Pentecost (Saturday evening), a vigil is served, consisting of Great Vespers, Litya, matins, and the First hour. All variable texts are from the Pentecostarion. Certain parts of the service normal sung on Sunday are omitted, such as "Having beheld the resurrection" (after the gospel), and "Holy is the Lord our God" (the Exapostilarion before the praises), and The Evlogitaria of the resurrection

On Sunday morning the Divine Liturgy is sung with special Festal antiphons for Pentecost, and an entrance hymn at the Small Entrance. "As many have been baptized into Christ..." is sung instead of the "Holy God..."

The vespers for the evening of the Monday of the Holy Spirit (served Sunday evening, and in some parishes, almost immediately after divine liturgy) includes three long prayers, called the kneeling prayers, which are said by the priest, while everyone kneels (for the first time since Holy Wednesday, before Pascha).

http://www.orthodox.net/questions/pentecost_1.doc
http://www.orthodox.net/questions/pentecost_1.html

¹ Philippians 3:19, KJV: "Whose end is destruction, whose God is their belly, and whose glory is in their shame, who mind earthly things.)" ... Their god is their appetite, they brag about shameful things, and they think only about this life here on earth."

² John 7:45-46 Then came the officers to the chief priests and Pharisees; and they said unto them, Why have ye not brought him? (46) The officers answered, Never man spake like this man.

³ Titus 2:11-14 For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men, (12) Teaching us that, denying ungodliness and worldly lusts, we should live soberly, righteously, and godly, in this present world; (13) Looking for that blessed hope, and the glorious appearing of the great God and our Saviour Jesus Christ; (14) Who gave himself for us, that he might redeem us from all iniquity, and purify unto himself a peculiar people, zealous of good works.

⁴ Hebrews 11:13 These all died in faith, not having received the promises, but having seen them afar off, and were persuaded of them, and embraced them, and confessed that they were strangers and pilgrims on the earth.

⁵ "Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered." (Rom 8:26)

⁶ Romans 8:26 Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered.

⁷ John 21:15 KJV "So when they had dined, Jesus saith to Simon Peter, Simon, *son* of Jonas, lovest thou me more than these? He saith unto him, Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love thee. He saith unto him, Feed my lambs." – and the following verses. This is the 11th matinal gospel – a piece of scripture so important that the church reads it at least 5 times a year.

⁸ Matthew 16:24 KJV Then said Jesus unto his disciples, If any *man* will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow me.

⁹ Number 2 of 3, mentioned at the beginning of the homily.

¹⁰ This story is so important that it is read on the 5th Sunday after Pascha, because it describes how we must react to God if we are to become enlightened. [Homilies on the Sunday of the Samaritan](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/index.html#The_Samaritan_Woman) woman are here:

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/index.html#The Samaritan Woman](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/index.html#The_Samaritan_Woman)

¹¹ John 7:37 "In the last day, that great day of the feast, Jesus stood and cried, saying, If any man thirst, let him come unto me, and drink. 38 He that believeth on me, as the scripture hath said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water." – read during Pentecost Liturgy.

¹² Number 3 of 3, the result.

¹³ During the Divine Liturgy, instead of the usual Trisagion Hymn ("Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal, Have mercy on us", we sing "As many have been baptized into Christ have put on Christ. Alleluia"

¹⁴ The prokeimenon for Pentecost and the Holy Apostles chanted and sung before the reading of the Epistle.

¹⁵ (Psa 58:3-4) The wicked are estranged from the womb: they go astray as soon as they be born, speaking lies. {4} Their poison is like the poison of a serpent: they are like the deaf adder that stoppeth her ear;

¹⁶ From the Akathist

¹⁷ (John 14:26) But the Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost, whom the Father will send in my name, he shall teach you all things, and bring all things to your remembrance, whatsoever I have said unto you. (and other places)

¹⁸ (Mat 23:37) O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, thou that killest the prophets, and stonest them which are sent unto thee, how often would I have gathered thy children together, even as a hen gathereth her chickens under her wings, and ye would not!

¹⁹ (John 16:13-15) Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth: for he shall not speak of himself; but whatsoever he shall hear, that shall he speak: and he will show you things to come. {14} He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall show it unto you. {15} All things that the Father hath are mine: therefore said I, that he shall take of mine, and shall show it unto you.

²⁰ (John 3:8) The wind bloweth where it listeth, and thou hearest the sound thereof, but canst not tell whence it cometh, and whither it goeth: so is every one that is born of the Spirit.

²¹ John 7:38

²² Matthew 25:41-46 Then shall he say also unto them on the left hand, Depart from me, ye cursed, into everlasting fire, prepared for the devil and his angels: (42) For I was an hungred, and ye gave me no meat: I was thirsty, and ye gave me no drink: (43) I was a stranger, and ye took me not in: naked, and ye clothed me not: sick, and in prison, and ye visited me not. (44) Then shall they also answer him, saying, Lord, when saw we thee an hungred, or athirst, or a stranger, or naked, or sick, or in prison, and did not minister unto thee? (45) Then shall he answer them, saying, Verily I say unto you, Inasmuch as ye did it not to one of the least of these, ye did it not to me. (46) And these shall go away into everlasting punishment: but the righteous into life eternal.

²³ Acts 2:1-11

²⁴ See John 3, the encounter of Jesus with Nicodemus. Read it all!

²⁵ John 7:37-52; 8:12

²⁶ Exodus 13:21-22 And the LORD went before them by day in a pillar of a cloud, to lead them the way; and by night in a pillar of fire, to give them light; to go by day and night: (22) He took not away the pillar of the cloud by day, nor the pillar of fire by night, *from* before the people.

²⁷ Mat 3:16-17 And Jesus, when he was baptized, went up straightway out of the water: and, lo, the heavens were opened unto him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove, and lighting upon him: (17) And lo a voice from heaven, saying, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.

²⁸ 1 Thessalonians 5:19 Quench not the Spirit.

²⁹ Mat 12:31 Wherefore I say unto you, All manner of sin and blasphemy shall be forgiven unto men: but the blasphemy *against* the Holy Ghost shall not be forgiven unto men.

³⁰ The Conversation of St Seraphim with Motovilov <http://orthodoxinfo.com/praxis/wonderful.aspx> "In acquiring this Spirit of God consists the true aim of our Christian life, while prayer, vigil, fasting, almsgiving and other good works done for Christ's sake are merely means for acquiring the Spirit of God."

³¹ "O Heavenly King" is a very common prayer used many times by Orthodox Christians: "O Heavenly King, Comforter, Spirit of Truth, You are everywhere and fill all things. Treasury of blessings and Giver of life: come and abide in us, and cleanse us from every impurity, and save our souls, O Good One!"

³² Sometimes, in sermons, I forget things and do not fulfill my promises. The fulfillment of this promise was after the sermons and liturgy ended.

³³ John 3:5-6 Jesus answered, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God. (6) That which is born of the flesh is flesh; and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.

³⁴ This partially explains what I am talking about: Rom 8:26 Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered.

³⁵ First Prayer of the Faithful, in the Presanctified liturgy of St Gregory the Dialogist, Pope of Rome: "First Prayer of the Faithful: "O God, great and worthy to be praised, who through the life-giving death of Thy Christ hast translated us from corruption to incorruption: Deliver thou all our senses from deadly passions; **setting over them as a good ruler the understanding that is in us.** Let our eye have no part in any evil sight; let our hearing be inaccessible to all idle words; and let our tongue be purged from unseemly speech. Purify our lips which praise thee, O Lord. Make our hands to abstain from evil deeds and to work only such things as are acceptable unto thee, establishing all our members and our minds by thy grace."
<http://www.orthodox.net/services/presanctified-liturgy-of-pope-gregory-the-dialogist.doc>

³⁶ I love David very much. It is been quite a while since his death, via suicide. I mention him by name because I want you to pray for him because I pray for him every day. I still feel an ache when I pray for him every day or mentioned his saying. I make this very personal note because every day I feel great sorrow that he was never able to stop the freight train in his head. May God help us have some quietness in our head, so that we can hear the still small voice of the Holy Spirit.

³⁷ 1Kings 19:11-13 And he said, Go forth, and stand upon the mount before the LORD. And, behold, the LORD passed by, and a great and strong wind rent the mountains, and brake in pieces the rocks before the LORD; *but* the LORD *was* not in the wind: and after the wind an earthquake; *but* the LORD *was* not in the earthquake: (12) And after the earthquake a fire; *but* the LORD *was* not in the fire: and after the fire a still small voice. (13) And it was so, when Elijah heard *it*, that he wrapped his face in his mantle, and went out, and stood in the entering in of the cave. And, behold, *there came* a voice unto him, and said, What doest thou here, Elijah?

³⁸ Joh 21:25 KJV And there are also many other things which Jesus did, the which, if they should be written every one, I suppose that even the world itself could not contain the books that should be written. Amen.

³⁹ The Hymns of Ascents are sung just before the Gospel is read in Sunday Matins. There are 8 sets, with 3 stanzas each, one set for each tone, except Tone 8, which has 4 stanzas.

⁴⁰ Just about any service – begins with the Trisagion prayers, which begin with "O Heavenly King" – Vespers, Matins, Some of the Hours, The Midnight Office, Compline, Morning and Evening prayers, before blessing anything, etc., etc.